



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Thursday, 12th March, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 12:47 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR
BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 5, *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* as well as the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 11th March, 2026, for correction.

Page 1...12?

[No correction was made to the Votes and Proceedings of Wednesday, 11th March, 2026]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have *Official Reports* of Wednesday, 4th March, 2026, and Thursday, 5th March, 2026, for correction.

Hon Members, let us start with Wednesday, 4th March, 2026. Any correction?

Yes, Mr Frank Afriyie.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much.

Mr Speaker, with your kind indulgence, let me walk you to column 5, the very last paragraph, the name of the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment, Dr Abdul-Rashid Hassan Pelpuo has been wrongly captured as “Abdul-Rahid”. So, if that could be deleted—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note.

Mr Afriyie: Once again, let me kindly invite you to the column numbered 74, the paragraph numbered 2, it reads:

“The Second Deputy Speaker; thank you very much Hon Samuel Awuku, let met turn to Hon Joseph Kwame Kumah”

I think the word “me” should be used to replace the word “met”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you for that observation. Any further correction?

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Wednesday, 4th March, 2026, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Let us turn to the *Official Report* of 5th March, 2026. Yes, Mr Sanja Nanja? I saw you on your feet, that is why I asked.

Any correction? Yes, Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah?

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, please let us turn to the column numbered 50 of the *Official Report*. The first paragraph says: “she is called Fatima Alhassan.” It should be Fatima Ahmed, A-H-M-E-D, not Alhassan.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, Table, take note.

Any further correction?

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Thursday, 5th March, 2026, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, let me acknowledge the presence of students from VRA International School, led by Isaac Angmo Anim, a teacher. They are from the Asuogyaman Constituency and they are 63 in number.

[Pupils of VRA International School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have St John Methodist School Complex, led by Brefia Jacob, the Head of Department. They are from the Tema East Constituency and are 85 in number.

[Pupils of St Methodist School Complex were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them to the Parliament of Ghana. I urge them to have a fruitful visit to Parliament. Kindly resume your seats? Yes, Alhaji Habib, you have the floor.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I want to seek your guidance on something that happened on the Floor, which I strongly feel was a procedural error. The Majority Leader made an application to you under Order 91 to get the Deputy Minister for Finance, Mr Thomas Ampem Nyarko to read a Statement with regards to audited accounts.

At the end of the day, there was a referral to the Public Accounts Committee. Mr Speaker, what I seek your guidance and clearance on here is whether it was the Statement that was referred to the Public Accounts Committee or it was the report of the Auditor-General that was referred to the Public Accounts Committee.

Mr Speaker, I say so because, if it is the report of the Auditor-General, then procedurally, it is definitely supposed to be advertised, for it to be laid and referred.

12:57 p.m.

If it is the Statement, then with the procedure, we can refer a Statement to the Committee. So, I want to seek that clarification. I tried to get information from the Chairperson of the Public Accounts Committee, and my information is that they have not received the Report as of now, even though we gave them three weeks to report back to the House, and they do not have it.

Mr Speaker, if you can guide us on this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. You rightly stated that the Statement was made under Order 91. No Report was presented to the House, but it was a Statement that was made in the House, and thereafter, a copy of the Statement was tabled. Matters arising from the Statement calls for an investigation, and I recall that the Majority Leader's submission is to the effect that there should be an Ad Hoc Committee or Special Committee to investigate. The Minority Leader's view was that, no, we have a Public Accounts Committee, which is a Committee seized with the authority to investigate such matters and looking at the rules, I agreed with the Minority Leader, hence a referral of the Statement to the Public Accounts Committee.

So, it is not the Report of the Auditor-General that is being referred and Hon Members, Statements can be transmitted

for an investigation, a notification or some other action to be taken when the Statement and then the debate occasions that.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, thank you for the clarification, because I am now clear in my mind that no Report was referred to the Public Accounts Committee, but rather a Statement.

Mr Speaker, if we read Standing Order 229(3), and with your permission, I read;

“(3) Pursuant to article 187 (2) and (5) of the Constitution, the Public Accounts Committee shall examine the public accounts of Ghana showing the appropriation and utilisation of the sums granted by Parliament to meet the public expenditure of the Government, and other accounts laid before Parliament.”

Mr Speaker, I do agree that Statements can be referred to Committees of Parliament, but the Public Accounts Committee is a special Committee of Parliament, that has its mandate defined within the Constitution in Article 187 and within our Standing Orders in Order 229. So, I do not know in which context that the Public Accounts Committee will be examining a Statement as this. If we can get further clarification on that, where the Public Accounts Committee can actually look at a Statement rather than the Report.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me hear from Hon Richard Acheampong.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I partly agree with Hon Habib Iddrisu, but the Public Accounts Committee is a Committee of Parliament. It is like the Finance Committee. A Member can make a Statement and looking at the content of it, that Statement can be referred to the Finance Committee to investigate the matter. So, we decided to set up an Ad Hoc Committee, and the Minority Leader said, no, we have an existing Committee which is clothed with that power so the matter should be referred to that existing Committee to investigate the matter and there was a closure to that Statement. I do not know why we want to revisit it. All of us agreed that the matter should be referred to the Public Accounts Committee, not to set up an Ad Hoc Committee so why are we revisiting the issue that all of us agreed that the Public Accounts Committee should investigate those matters?

Mr Speaker, I think you were right to refer the matter to the Public Accounts Committee. If not, we would set up an Ad Hoc Committee to investigate the matter, if that is your wish.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If there is a matter that can be considered by any Committee of Parliament per our rules, you do not form an Ad Hoc or Special Committee to deal with that, but we rather refer the matter to that substantive

Committee. So, every Parliamentary Committee has the power to conduct an investigation to any matter within their domain.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, as my good Friend, Hon Richard Acheampong, was making his contribution, I just want him to know that there is something that has been happening within the week, which is not good.

Mr Speaker, I must commend you; you are always punctual. You always come on time, wait for us, we come to Conclave before we come in. Sometimes, it is not that we want to raise quorum, but the fact is that we do not have our Colleagues who have a super Majority of 189, and at the moment we are just 20 in the Chamber. It does not speak well of you, and you have the authority. So, the Second Deputy Majority Whip should try to get his Members to always come. We have just passed the 24-Hour Economy Bill yet their Members do not come to the Chamber. Look at the numbers that they have here today. It is not good. So, he should try his best to make sure that they have their numbers always in the Chamber because if they do not have, we will be forced to call for a quorum to

commence Business, or a decision-making quorum on things that we want to do. We do not want to do that so, I am giving him this piece of advice.

Mr Speaker, I have been a Deputy Majority Whip before, and I understand. The Minister for Roads and Highways was a Minority Chief Whip. So, I know when one is in the Majority. He has not been a Majority Whip before; he was in the Minority and I was in the Majority, and I have been in the Minority before. So, Minister for Roads and Highways, maybe he should come here when he is speaking. But what I am saying is from experience.

Second Deputy Majority Whip, I am telling him that, he has 189 Members. We do not always want to make it—We want to work. We want to help him. He said they have passed a policy, 24-Hour Economy, even though it is not working. It is just an Act. Nothing is going on and yet, his Members cannot even come and help with this 24-Hour Economy. Look at us, out of the 29, we are less than 20. It is not good. When we continue to do this, it will become a problem.

Mr Speaker, the other thing is that if the Second Deputy Majority Whip can find a way to programme the Minister for Foreign Affairs. There is a war between Iran and Israel, and Ghanaians are there. When there was war between Russia and Ukraine, Hon Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa, who was the then Ranking Member of the Committee on Foreign

Affairs and Regional Integration, was in Ukraine. I do not know what he is still doing. Rather, he is in South Korea with the President. What is he doing there? He is in a private jet to South Korea with the President. As a Minister, he should come and brief us in this House, because we are the representatives of the people and we need to know the position of Government. Whether the Government is supporting Iran, or the United States of America, then we will be able to know the position of the Government. We need to know that.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I think our Colleague raised a very important point and even when I was sitting on the other Side, it was an issue I was passionate about. I think the advice that all of us should endeavour to be coming to the House on time is a very important one and I support him on that score that we should all work, especially the Whips, to make sure that our Colleagues are in the Chamber.

Mr Speaker, indeed, you are always here. I disagree with him and let me take him back to memory lane. They became a Minority even before the 2024 elections, I was a Majority Chief Whip for two weeks before the 2024 election and there is nothing, they can do about it. What they should be worried about is the fact that Hon Kennedy Ohene Agyepong is very unhappy because apparently, he has been giving them sewing machines

and cornmills but when the time came for them to vote for him, only the Minority Leader and his constituents voted for him. Kennedy lost in all of their constituencies. When they have been taking sewing machines and cornmills from him for almost four years, they should be worried about that one.

Mr Speaker, I agree with them that we must all come to Parliament.

1:07 p.m.

On the same score, I was Majority Chief Whip for two weeks before the elections, and indeed, Hon Kennedy is unhappy that many of them took his corn mills, sewing machines and never voted for him, especially Hon Habib. The Minority Leader did vote for him; did he take the corn mill? *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Stephen Amoah?

Mr Stephen Amoah: Mr Speaker, I think this is an august House of records, and any statement made here has to be taken very seriously, with all the credible and tangible evidence that one day will not come and haunt us.

My very good Brother and Friend has made a very serious statement that somebody can even design and draw in implication of corruption, because I wonder where and when he was told by Hon Ken that he gave machines to a

certain number of Members of Parliament (MPs)—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, following my Leader's advice, I want to drop the case.

Thank you. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Nitiwul.

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I think the First Deputy Whip on the Minority Side has raised an important point.

Mr Speaker, the Members of the Majority Side are 26. How on earth can they explain that at the exact time you were supposed to come, you came? The people of Ghana gave them a super Majority to come and work, and 26 of them are here. Their Leader is not here—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, I did not count you. If I count you in addition, they would be 27, but I did not count Mr Speaker because I specifically said Mr Speaker was very punctual. I am talking of those who are sitting here, who can vote and debate.

Some Hon Members: But, Mr Speaker can vote.

Mr Nitiwul: But Mr Speaker cannot debate. So, Mr Speaker, the Majority needs to address the concerns raised by the First Deputy Minority Chief Whip, because there are serious matters on the table here today, and we need their numbers to decide on them for Ghana; we need your numbers. They cannot tell

the people of Ghana that they have over 190 Members of Parliament and only 26 of them are here to work. Where are the others? When he was a Chief Whip, was he not asking the same questions? So, we will not allow them to divert any attention. He wants to be a smart former Chief Whip; we will not allow him to divert any attention. He should answer to the fact that his people are not here. Where are they? Are they disappointed already?

Mr Speaker, you see the heat on them from the recruitment process, where 500,000 people have applied for 5,000 jobs. When they knew they could only recruit 5,000 people, they opened 500,000 jobs; that heat is coming on them is why they cannot come to Parliament, because they think their people will visit them in Parliament.

Mr Speaker, they must come, and the people must look for them. They voted for them; they cannot run away from their constituents because of the recruitment scam. They would not run away; they would hold them responsible.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, first of all, I still need to commend you on your punctuality, saying that our Brothers on the other Side

are becoming notorious, but that is up to them. They promised their people a 24-Hour Economy. I saw the President, holding a clock of 24-Hour Economy, and there is nothing going on.

Mr Speaker, and they felt that they were going to open their recruitment to 35 years. Critical matters, including those who passed English and Mathematics, were taken off just to do propaganda, and then they opened to take 506,000 people, and then they took monies from them, GHC220.00 per head.

Mr Speaker, that is not even the last part. On Medicals—those monies have to be refunded. They have to refund those monies to these young men. They caused only company to run the programme, that is TrybeNet, and then while they were trying to upload, they turned off the light, *dumsor*. They were to write an aptitude test; they were given 15 minutes to do the aptitude test, and within that period, *dumsor*. Then they are using money to buy data, yet the data is not working, and the data vanishes. Meanwhile, they are increasing electricity tariffs by 28 per cent. This same 28 per cent could not get them to even buy electricity to hold on to do their exams.

Mr Speaker, I do not know about you, but the unemployment rate is becoming a national security risk, a problem, and we are worried. We did not tell them that we were going to open up to 35 years.

We did not tell them that they could succeed by just going on and doing all manner of aptitude tests, which never came off. It is becoming a problem. Then, when they finish, they come and tell us that Ukraine is 7,000 kilometres away; meanwhile, they are here, and are already complaining. For people to go and drill boreholes in cocoa farms. How does one go and drill boreholes in cocoa farms and then start using water holes? Pay their money; Pay the GH¢6,000.00. They promised them GH¢6,000.00.

Mr Speaker, people are dying, and then they come and tell us that they bought private jets. The President travels in a private jet to South Korea. Is the jet for him or for his brother? For that one, we even need that full disclosure. His brother only buys jets when the President is in power. We need full disclosure on all of these things.

Mr Speaker, these are key matters.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Alhaji Sulemana?

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana: Yes, Mr Speaker, I am very grateful.

I think that this House is a very serious House. This House is where records are kept for generations yet unborn, and so when we are making statements on this Floor, it is important that we back those statements with evidence, especially when the people we

are accusing are not here. We have just been told that it is a deliberate act, and that we asked applicants to go and answer questions, and then, while they are answering, we turn off the lights. This is a serious statement, and I ask that this be expunged from the records unless he is able to give us evidence.

Mr Speaker, when you raised the issue of poor attendance, we are all speaking to that fact. But it did not start today. I remember very well that at a point, there was even a move to bring what we call a Decision Day. It was because attendance was very poor, and this was during their regime. It is an issue that we all have to come together and see how to resolve it, and stop playing politics with it. What has this got to do with Mr Ablakwa in South Korea?

Indeed, when Mr Ablakwa was in opposition, he travelled on matters like this to ensure that he was able to adduce evidence when he was speaking on this platform. I expect my Brother, who is the Minority representative for Foreign Affairs, to be in Iran today, to get evidence, and come and tell this House that this is exactly what is happening there. It is only when we have this evidence that we are able to tell whether this Government will support A or support B. If we do not bring that evidence, he should please not tell us to choose where we belong. This is a sovereign nation, and a decision as to

which side we will support should be a decision emanating from this House.

So, Mr Speaker, I want to appeal to my Colleagues. They have done well over the past few days that we have been here, such that any time they come, they cooperate, they take part in decisions, and I think that is patriotism, and I applaud them for that. So, let us continue Government Business. We have enough numbers to do Business.

1:17 p.m.

When they talk about 24-Hour Economy, it seems to me that some of them are refusing to understand the concept. The 24-Hour Economy does not mean that this House will be full before we start Business. The 24-Hour Economy does not mean that we must all come here before major decisions are taken. So, they should go back to the concept, read it and we can move together to ensure that this country is able to implement it very well. With this, Mr Speaker, I want to thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me place on record that the observation made by the First Deputy Minority Whip is very apt and timely. It is for a good reason that Leadership should have Conclave with the Speaker before the commencement of the House. We adjourned the House to 12 o'clock, so, that usually must precede the 12 o'clock Sitting. It is also a very good observation that though we are voted for to represent the very people that voted

for us in Parliament, numbers in Parliament is not very encouraging. So, I will urge the respective Whips to work on attendance of Members in Parliament. It is not good that we have been voted to come to Parliament, yet will not be in Parliament to do the very Business we have been voted to come and conduct.

Hon Members, with the issues relating to Iran, it may have some diplomatic and security reasons. So, we should be careful in order not to trivialise that on the floor of Parliament. On this note, I intend not to open any argument but to go to the item numbered 6.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor —
rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I have allowed this to happen outside the rules. So, sometimes Hon Members have to bear with me. I have accommodated everybody. I took more people from the Minority Side than the Majority Side. Sometimes we do certain things which create a bad impression. So, Hon Member, with all due respect, I am pleading with you on this occasion. I am pleading with you.

Let us move to the item numbered 6, Questions. I will call on the Minister of State for Climate Change and Sustainability to take the designated seat while I call on the Minority Chief Whip, Hon Frank Annoh-Dompreh to pose the Question numbered 701.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

OFFICE OF CLIMATE CHANGE AND SUSTAINABILITY

Status of Carbon Credit Agreement between Ghana and British Petroleum

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (NPP — Nsawam-Adoagyiri): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister of State for Climate Change and Sustainability the progress made thus far towards the signing of a new carbon credit agreement between Ghana and British Petroleum (BP).

Minister of State for Climate Change and Sustainability (Mr Issifu Baba Seidu): Mr Speaker, Ghana initiated discussions with British Petroleum (BP) in 2023 and exchanged a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to establish a robust framework that provides regulatory certainty for the generation of Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation (CORSIA)-labelled credits. This engagement has progressed to the development of a draft Framework Agreement, which has been technically negotiated between Ghana and British Petroleum (BP). In 2025, the draft underwent legal review by the Attorney-General's Department and the Environmental Protection Authority (EPA)—Carbon Market Office (CMO).

Following this review, Ghana's consolidated comments were formally transmitted to British Petroleum (BP)

through the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology (MEST) for consideration and revision. Ghana is currently awaiting British Petroleum's (BP) response to advance the process toward conclusion.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, within the confines of Standing Order 88(7)(a) and Standing Order 89, I proceed with my follow-up Questions.

Mr Speaker, if you may bear with me, let me read the first paragraph of Hon Minister's Answers.

“Ghana initiated discussions with British Petroleum (BP) in 2023 and exchanged a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to establish a robust framework that provides regulatory certainty for the generation of Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation (CORSIA)-labelled credits.”

So, my follow-up is based on the Hon Minister's Answers. That is why I read it to him. Now, what were the highlights—I am not saying he should give me verbatim of the MoU that was established of which your good self has alluded to in the first paragraph of your Answers.

Mr First Deputy Minister: You are talking about the highlights contained in the MoU in 2023?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The Minister just got up eagerly to answer my Question. I am not saying he should produce verbatim. The Minister knows what to do. He is an experienced person when it comes to the subject matter. In 2023, he has said that a MoU was established. He should apprise this House what the highlights of this MoU were. It cannot be offensive of Standing Order 89.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, I explained over and over that unless we change our rules, my understanding is that ministers are not supposed to be taken by surprise. Memorandum of Understanding is a legal document. Now, your Question is to ask the Minister the progress made thus far toward the signing of a new carbon credit agreement between Ghana and British Petroleum. In asking a supplementary question, you are asking the Minister the highlight of a memorandum executed between Ghana and British Petroleum? You are saying that this Question does not offend Standing Order 89?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, I am not challenging you on the interpretation of the rules. The Minister had the opportunity to answer the Question within the limitation and confines of the letter. He decided to speak to an MoU. My original Question did not reference MoU. He spoke to MoU. Nobody forced him to speak to MoU. He mentioned MoU; hence, it is

reasonable that I can ask him Questions on the MoU he spoke to. I am not asking him to produce verbatim the MoU signed in 2023. I am asking for highlights. Mr Speaker, please allow him to answer the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, I beg to differ with all due respect.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Well, the interpretation of the rules is in your hands. We may have to revisit this matter some other day. But I think that my question is— He is ready to answer.

I will ask a different Question. I will reframe my question. Do I have your permission?

1:27 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The Minister's Answer says that Ghana as a Republic submitted its consolidated comments formally to BP. Can he give this House a rundown in terms of the key variables in these comments that were formally submitted by this Republic to the BP in the same context?

Mr Seidu: Mr Speaker, Ghana's comments were the legal opinion of the state. I do not have that legal opinion to share with the House today. So, if the Hon Member wants to have a legal opinion, which are the comments that

were filed on behalf of Ghana, then I would suggest that he should file a Question directed to the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice to take care of that.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The Minister in the last paragraph of his Answers says:

“Ghana is currently awaiting British Petroleum’s response to advance the process towards conclusion.”

We have been waiting on the BP for a year now. What has the Ministry been doing to support the facilitation of the progress of this project within this period of waiting on the BP to formally respond to us?

Mr Seidu: We need to recognise that Ghana is unable to make progress until we get the final response from BP. This is because the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice reviewed the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) and came out with a legal opinion. So, for us to make any move, we will have to get the response from BP. That is what will make it binding for us to make progress.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I can appreciate the Minister’s challenge. So is it the case that until BP responds—If we look at the chronology of event that has happened from 2023, it has been a steady progress. I am sure the Minister

concedes to that. Then suddenly, there is silence. There must be something wrong.

Is it the case that Attorney-General and Minister for Justice does not find this carbon credit a worthy cause to pursue? Or is it the case that we have not done our homework well? Which is which? What should be the way out of this supposed *cul de sac*?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, what is the question?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The question is, what is the Minister, or for that matter, the Ministry, doing to get us out of this long waiting period?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But the Minister in his Answer indicated that the memorandum was reviewed, and the legal opinion was forwarded to them. They are waiting for their response.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, if you would permit me to make some comment. I do not want to be offensive of Order 88(7). But we must be progressive as a country. We cannot put our hands on our back and say that BP has not responded, therefore we are just sitting down waiting. It is a consolidated agreement between Ghana and the BP. Progressively, the British Petroleum has shown dedication to pursue this path of carbon credit. So, there must be a problem. That is why I am asking the Minister if he is considering an

alternative way of getting a response, as soon as possible. It is a valid option.

Mr Seidu: We will look at that. I am sure if I consult the Hon Member who has experience in the climate space, he will assist us to navigate the waters. But let us remember that until BP gets back to us with the consent and the legal opinion given to them, we are unable to make progress as a country. But I will consult the Hon Member. Thank you.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We on this Side, out of patriotism and for the progress of our country are available. Except that it is difficult to get the Minister. For the past one month, I have been trying to get him, but it has been difficult. Table Office will bear me out. But I can pledge for the record that on any day, at any time—It is not just me; there are experts here. Hon John Darko is also a very strong person in the environment. So, we will be more than willing to assist. There is also Hon Nyarko Osei. We are all available to assist the Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I reference the Hon Minister's response that the draft review from the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice was sent to BP in 2025 and we are currently awaiting the response from BP to make progress.

So, my question to the Minister is that, in his communication to BP, were there any timelines that he indicated for which we can expect the response from BP? We are in March 2026; we do not know exactly when in 2025 the communication went to BP.

Mr Seidu: There were no timelines.

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minister standing in the Despatch Box in answering the Minority Chief Whip indicated that the Ministry has made a lot of progress. Can he specifically identify and share with us a specific policy success which is part of what he described as a lot of progress for our records?

Mr Seidu: I would want to suggest that the Hon Member and the Leader of the Minority Side should file a Question so that we will know exactly what he is looking for because we have a lot of information. Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Minister's approach is most contemptuous of Parliament. *[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, let me finish. When a Question is admitted, the Minister cannot mount the Despatch Box and say that the Questions are not admissible therefore, he should file another Question.

Mr Dafeamekpor — rose —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The admissibility of my question—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: One after the other. So, Hon Dafeamekpor take your seat.

1:37 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minister of State, in response to the Hon Member for Nsawam/Adoagyiri, said that his sector has made a lot of progress. Now, my supplementary question as a follow-up was to the effect that, he said and I quote: “there are a lot of progress they have made as part of the success story in the sector”. He should identify one and share that success story with us. That was my supplementary question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The answer of the Minister is at page 39 of the *Order Paper*. Where in the answer did the Minister indicate that he has made a lot of progress?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker with respect, there was a supplementary question. He is right here. In his answer to the supplementary question, he indicated that a lot of progress has been made and went further to call on the questioner that if they have some input, since they are experts in that field, they are welcome. Mr Speaker, is it the case that we will not put things in context? He said a lot of progress has been made and that he welcomes further ideas and my question is very specific that; the progress that he has made, which he said they have made a lot of progress, he should identify one and share with us. He mounts the Despatch Box and tells the House that he would

suggest that the Minority Leader files a Question to demand the specific thing that he is sharing with us.

So, when he was telling the people of Ghana that he has made a lot of progress, he did not have a single success story in mind? He did not have one? Now, he wants to get there and then determine the admissibility of the Question? Mr Speaker, you have admitted the question. His job was to answer. If he does not have the fact readily available, the rules allow him to plead with the chair for him to be granted leave to come back again. But he cannot mount the Despatch Box when a question has been admitted and say that he wants me to file another Question. I am not asking something new. He said they have made a lot of progress so he should tell us what single progress they have made.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me place on record that a question to a Minister is not cross-examination. You are asking the question for a Minister to bring facts to bear. And the very Question on the Floor is to ask the Minister the progress made thus far towards the signing of a new Carbon Credit Agreement between Ghana and British Petroleum. And then the Answer of the Minister regarding what has happened is captured on page 39 of the *Order Paper*. So, where I sit, I even have a difficulty with the supplementary question.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, you have always been talking about rules. Mr Speaker, if you want to change your mind to say that

the question that you have admitted, you want to change your mind, I will yield to you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, I am not changing my mind with all due respect, Minority Leader. But the Question asked has been answered on page 39. What other progress are you asking of apart from the progress that the Minister has come to answer on page 39? That is what is bringing the ambiguity. But let me hear Hon Dafeamekpor.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, first of all, the Minister never said what is being attributed to him by the Minority Leader. No, he never. It was the supplementary question from the Minority Chief Whip that suggested that there has been steady progress. That was the phrase. He said “a steady progress”. He is saying, “a lot of progress”. There are marked difference. He never said so. So, it was a Question that was put to him. He never said that there has been a lot of progress. It was the suggestion that was put to him. So, if they are looking for specificity of that — the Minister is saying yes, but file a specific Question, then I will provide those details. Then he said he does not like the answer and he is intimidating him. Why?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the records must reflect that once a question is admitted, it is not for the Minister concerned to raise an issue of admissibility. He knows that I listened to him but he is becoming one intolerant Majority Chief Whip [TO BE EXPUNGED]. Mr Speaker, I asked the question and Mr Speaker admitted the

question— *[Interruption]*—then, he should say it for the record.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I take offence to the reference to me that I am intolerant. I am not and the Minority Leader will have to withdraw and apologise to me. It is a tournament of ideas. There is no intolerance about this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, you are both in Leadership. I always plead with Leaders to be careful with the language you use against each other and whatever we say is in the record for generations. I believe you would not be happy if your Colleague on his feet said you are intolerable.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, he used the same language; we all heard him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I have not heard it.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, but I am telling you, I am sitting right in front of him. He said it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, do not get into this. He is my mate. Mr Speaker, stay away from this. It is between the two of us; ignore him. He is laughing; he knows what he wants to achieve. He wants to introduce confusion —

Mr Agbodza — rose —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: He should sit down. He is not in Leadership; he should go to his Ministry. The contractors are looking for him. He comes here to cause trouble. Mr Speaker, I know what he wants to achieve, but I will not pursue this. I want my Chief Whip to proceed with the second Question. I will let him be until another time. Minority Chief whip should continue, but this Minister that we have gotten today, we will get him again. Mr Speaker, for your sake, I will let him be for the Minority Chief Whip to continue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the phrase “the Majority Chief whip is becoming intolerable” is ordered to be expunged from the record. The Minority Chief Whip had his turn and has exhausted his supplementary questions before giving the floor to Hon Boamah-Nyarko at your back before he gets to your end.

In the absence of any further supplementary questions, we move to the Question numbered 702, which also stands in the name of Hon Frank Annoh-Dompoh.

Implementation of Carbon Credit Agreements and Private Sector Involvement in the Validation of Carbon Credits Transfer

Mr Annoh-Dompoh : Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister of State in charge of Climate Change and Sustainability what the Ministry is doing so far to facilitate the implementation of

the terms of the following Carbon Credit Agreements signed and the involvement of the private sector in the validation of carbon credits transfer: (i) Ghana – Switzerland (ii) Ghana – Sweden (iii) Ghana – Singapore (iv) Ghana – South Korea (v) Ghana – Liechtenstein.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Issifu Seidu: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, According to Section 2.7.1.3 of Ghana’s Framework on carbon markets, the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology (MEST) and the Carbon Market Office (CMO) must work together with the Minister of State in charge of Climate Change and Sustainability on issues related to carbon market activities.

The status of development and implementation of the listed carbon market agreements is as follows:

i. Ghana – Switzerland: The Ghana-Switzerland agreement is under implementation with 18 projects. The project covers electric vehicles, composting, rice cultivation, clean cooking, solar PV, efficient ACs, and biogas.

The agreement also issued and transferred the first and largest Paris-Agreement carbon credit (ITMO) on the Ghana carbon registry in 2025.

The table below highlights the progress of implementation with the key milestones;

Duration	Key milestone
February 2020	Ghana and Switzerland signed the Article 6 cooperation MOU
November 2020	Ghana and Switzerland signed the Article 6 cooperation agreement
July 2021	Ghana and Switzerland adopted a roadmap for implementing the Article 6 cooperation agreement
August 2023	A Technical Implementation Committee was established between the CMO and BAFU (Swiss Federal Office for the Environment)
2021 to date	Developing 18 carbon market projects under the Ghana-Switzerland agreement
2021 to date	2 carbon market projects are being developed under UNDP support. a. Both received authorisation from Ghana and Switzerland, totalling 2.7 million tonnes of ITMOs by 2030 b. Waste-to-compost project (1.5 million tonnes) – under implementation and monitoring c. Alternative wet and dry project (1.2 million tonnes)- Under implementation and monitoring 16 carbon market projects are being developed under the Klik Foundation
Feb 2024	Established a CMO-Klik working group to track project development.
June 2025	Issuance of the first and largest ITMOs in Africa and globally of 11,733 tonnes of Paris-aligned carbon credits.
July 2025	First-ever transfer of the largest ITMOs of 11,733 for a project on the transformative clean cookstove initiative in rural Ghana. In 2026, additional ITMOs are expected to be issued and transferred from cookstoves, compost, and rice cultivation.

ii. **Ghana – Sweden:** The Ghana- Sweden agreement is under implementation with 3 energy-related projects: one is under

validation, while two are still in development.

Ghana-Sweden has established a coordinating committee to receive and

consider project applications and authorisation requests.

The table below highlights the progress of implementation with the key milestones;

Duration	Key Milestone
November 2021	Ghana and Sweden signed the Article 6 cooperation MOU
May 2024	Ghana and Sweden signed the Article 6 cooperation agreement
October 2024	Held a meeting of the Ghana-Sweden coordinating committee to oversee the implementation of the agreement
August 2024	Commencement of procurement of 2 carbon market projects for implementation in Ghana
Oct 2024	The Swedish Energy Agency (SEA) visited Accra on a project sourcing mission and to participate in the coordinating committee meeting
December 2024	CMO held the first informal meeting with SEA to discuss the way forward for project implementation
2024	The Swedish Energy Agency (SEA) concluded the selection of 2 carbon projects in solar PV and electric cars for further development
2024	The C&I Solar Photovoltaic and Storage programme reached the validation stage
2025	The project pipeline increased to 3. All of which are energy-related projects, and the current status includes; a. Infra futura Ghana Limited- (Validation stage) b. TFI Power Company Limited- (Onboarding stage) c. Solar Taxi Company Limited and Southpole- (Procurement stage)

- iii. **Ghana – Singapore:** The Ghana-Singapore agreement is under implementation with 39 projects at different stages of development. Four of them have reached an authorisation decision point.

Also, a joint committee has been established that receives and assesses projects for authorisation.

The table below highlights the progress of implementation with the key milestones;

Duration	Key Milestone
November 2021	Ghana-Singapore held an initial contact meeting at COP26
February 2022	Ghana and Singapore exchanged a letter of intent on Article 6 voluntary cooperation
November 2022	Singapore and Ghana substantively conclude negotiations on the Implementation Agreement on Cooperative Approaches
May 2024	The Ghana-Singapore carbon market implementation agreement was signed.
September 2024	Ghana-Singapore launched the first call for carbon market projects
September 2024-2025	Three joint Committee Meetings between Ghana and Singapore on the Implementation Agreement to consider the project request
January 2025 to date	The status to date includes: - 39 project ideas submitted to the Ministry, including renewable energy (solar PV, biodiesel, clean cooking technology), e-vehicles, charging stations, afforestation, mangrove restoration, water treatment, and biochar. - A joint committee has been established to review and issue 24 no-objection approvals from both Governments. - 4 projects on water treatment and improved cookstoves have reached a decision point on Government authorisation. - Of which 8 stage A applications are yet to be reviewed at the technical working level - Project includes all relevant sectors (cookstoves, waste-to-energy, water treatment etc.) - The projects are expected to provide access to clean water and improve the cooking experience in rural Ghana, while also attracting capital investment, generating carbon revenue for project owners, and Government fees.

1:57 p.m.

Ghana – South Korea: Ghana-South Korea bilateral agreement is under legal review by the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice before Cabinet Approval and Parliamentary ratifications. Five projects are being developed in anticipation of the Ghana-South Korea agreement.

Mr Speaker, let me be quick to mention that these answers came before the President went to South Korea but I would still give details of the key milestones and duration in the table below.

The table below highlights the progress of implementation with the key milestones;

Duration	Key Milestone
December 2023	Technical negotiations concluded, and both countries have met the country participation requirements, with minutes of negotiations adopted at COP28
March 2024 up to date	The Office of the Attorney General and the Ministry of Justice finalised a legal review of the draft agreement
2023- date	Pipeline applications are 5 in total - of which 3 are cookstove projects - of which 1 is a water treatment project - of which 1 is a waste-to- energy project

Ghana – Liechtenstein: The Ghana-Liechtenstein Agreement is still being negotiated between the two countries.

The table below highlights the progress of implementation with the key milestones;

Duration	Key Milestone
December 2023	Discussions to cooperate bilaterally
November 2024	Agreement at COP29 to initiate text negotiations
December 2024	Discussions on general technical negotiations of text

Involvement of Validation Bodies in the Carbon Market Validation Process

Mr Speaker, with respect to the involvement of the private sector in the validation of carbon credits, Pursuant to

Section 9 of the Ghana Carbon Market Framework (GCMF), the Carbon Market Office (CMO) engages internationally accredited independent validation bodies to assess Project Design Documents and mitigation activity design documents submitted for authorisation.

The CMO has onboarded 24 validation bodies, of which approximately 14 have actively participated in validation assignments. As part of the onboarding process, validators must meet established accreditation criteria, including compliance with the Ghana Carbon Registry (GCR) onboarding procedures, submission of Terms of Reference (ToR), and appointment of a local expert.

The designated local expert must actively participate in the validation activities to ensure stakeholder engagement, adherence to local content requirements and capacity development.

CMO evaluates the performance of independent bodies through an annual performance and conformance assessment of those onboarded onto the GCR using defined key performance indicators. Based on the assessment results, the CMO may add new or remove underperforming Validators from its database. This performance oversight strengthens credibility, accountability, and integrity within Ghana's carbon market system.

In addition, the EPA-CMO has established a Roster of Experts (RoE) database, which will be published on its website. Recognised Designated Operational Entities (DOEs) are required to appoint a qualified local expert from this roster to participate in validation assignments.

With technical support from Gold Standard, Ghana has trained 24 local

experts in validation processes and these experts have been formally onboarded onto the Roster of Experts (RoE) database to strengthen national capacity.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip, any supplementary questions?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, indeed, Mr Speaker. From the outset, let me commend the Minister for a detailed response, but that is not enough. Now, he has given six tabular responses which encapsulate the high points of what has been achieved in terms of all the carbon agreements we have entered into. Now, if you take time and go through the tables, more than 90 per cent of the achievement occurred between 2020 to 2024. It appears to me that after 2024, little has happened and I want to find out from the Minister what is giving rise to this challenge and how he is going to deal with this challenge?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In 2024?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: After 2024.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Minister?

Mr Seidu: Mr Speaker, I do not know where the Hon Member is reading from, but if you look at what I have done, I have captured up to 2025 and if you look at Ghana – Singapore for instance, I said September 2024 – 2025, three joint Committee Meetings between Ghana

and Singapore on the Implementation Agreement was considered. I also said in January 2025 to date, which means that work is being done. So, I am sure if you run through the others, you will also see that we will have activity for each of them from 2025 to date. So, work is ongoing on all these projects. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any further questions?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Well, Minister, we will leave this for another day because when I go into it—and I do not want to do that banter with you. So, if you are claiming in 2025 you have achieved something, that is fine. Mr Speaker, I would ask my second follow up question. Reference to the first table which highlights the progress of implementation, that is from 2021 to date, February 2024, June 2025, where carbon market projects are being developed under UNDP support, Carbon market projects are being developed under the Klik Foundation, alternative wet and dry project (1.2 million tonnes), and so on and so forth, my question is, this appears a technical response. Any layman who picks this may not be able to appreciate. How does this translate in terms of its benefits to this country?

Mr Seidu: Mr Speaker, I am not very clear with his question.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, this is my second follow up so, I still have one more follow up. He is asking for a repeat or an elucidation of this question so, it has nothing to do with

my third follow up. So, I am saying—let me read to you:

“2021 to date —2 carbon market projects are being developed under UNDP support.

d. Both received authorisation from Ghana and Switzerland, totalling 2.7 million tonnes of ITMOs by 2030

e. Waste-to-compost project (1.5 million tonnes) – under implementation and monitoring

f. Alternative wet and dry project (1.2 million tonnes)- Under implementation and monitoring

2:07 p.m.

Establish a CMO-Klik working group to track project development. First-ever transfer of the largest ITMOs of 11,733 for a project on the transformative clean cook stove initiative in rural Ghana, and so on. I am asking how this translates, in practical terms, into benefits for our country?

Mr Seidu: Mr Speaker, Ghana has signed on to some international protocols. The Paris Agreement gave birth to the nationally determined contributions, and all these things are expected to feed into these agreements that we have signed. The ultimate aim is to achieve the 1.5-degree target that all countries have signed on to.

These projects are supposed to inure to the benefits of Ghanaians, and specifically to sustainability in the work that we do. We all agree that these projects and the development that we are embarking on are supposed to be done in a very safe way, so that future generations do not suffer from these things that we are doing. So, there are protocols that we have signed on to, and these are some of the benefits that we intend to derive from them.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, indeed, Mr Speaker.

In his Answer on the Ghana-Singapore Agreement, he said that,

“the Ghana-Singapore agreement was under implementation with 39 projects at different stages of development. Four of them have reached an authorisation decision point.”

He mentioned 39, then said four, which means four of the 39 have reached the authorisation point. What this effectively means is that 35 of them are outstanding.

My question is, what is he going to do to facilitate the implementation of the outstanding 35 out of the 39?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Seidu: Mr Speaker, I have already said that we have established a joint committee that is responsible for receiving these proposals and also assessing progress made on these projects. So, we only have to collaborate well with the joint working committee that has oversight responsibility over these projects.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kingsley Nyarko.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, on page 44, the last but one paragraph, he indicated that the EPA-CMO has established a roster of experts database, which will be published on its website. I am asking whether the publication has been done or if he has an idea when it is going to be done? Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Seidu: Mr Speaker, I do not have the timing, but I am told that they will publish it on their website.

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, yes, I get that indication. But will he be kind enough to follow up and ask when it is going to be done?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: He said he did not have the information.

Prof K. Nyarko: So, he will find out and come back to us?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes.

Prof K. Nyarko: All right, thank you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it has been suggested to the Minister that since about 2024 or after 2024, very little has been done. Now, can he confirm to this House that, for instance, under the Ghana-Switzerland Agreement, activities such as the issuance of 11,733 tonnes of Paris-aligned carbon credits have been issued just under Ghana-Switzerland alone, and that in the same 2025, there has been a first-ever transfer of the largest utmost of 11,733 for project on transformative claim in cook stoves, compost and rice cultivation just under the Ghana and Switzerland alone in 2025 forward.

Then again, under Ghana-Sweden, from 2025, the following projects have been undertaken. Then the projects include the three energy-related pipelines, and are implemented as follows; Infra-Futura Ghana Limited is at the validation stage. TFI Power Company Limited. That is on the boarding stage and then Solar Taxi Company Limited is at the procurement stage. That is, these projects have been undertaken in 2025 under the Ghana-Switzerland Agreement alone.

Finally, under Ghana-Singapore, as many as eight activities were undertaken under his guidance in 2025; if he can confirm this for the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minister, the question is for you to confirm.

Mr Seidu: Mr Speaker, I confirm that all these that have stated happen between the period of 2025 to date, and it is ongoing.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I thank the Minister sincerely for attending upon the House to respond to all the Questions scheduled for him. Hon Minister, accordingly, you are hereby discharged.

Hon Members, we have exhausted the Questions listed for today. Therefore, Question time has ended. Any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may we move to the item numbered 7 and take a couple of Statements advertised there?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, on Tuesday or Monday, we had the opportunity of discussing taking the Motion on the Gold for Reserves and also continuing the debate on the revocation of employment. My understanding is that if we are able to finish the Statements, then we can take the Motion.

2:17 p.m.

I actually did that with him, so he should not sit here and act like he does not know.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, I am also a Deputy Speaker, I sometimes work on instructions. So, you know what to do in that regard. By doing the needful.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, what is the needful? I am guided.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Probably, if you do not understand my language, you could see me for guidance.

Mr Shaib: Very well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 7, Statements. Should we go by this order? The rules apply. If you are not here to make your Statement—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray that we start with the item numbered 7 (b).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Should we start with the item numbered 7 (e). Hon Members, before doing so, let me also acknowledge students from Uaddara Basic School, led by Kwame Amponsah, a teacher. They are from Subin Constituency and are 100 in number.

[Pupils of Uaddara Basic School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have M/A Basic School in Ahwenease led by Mariam Sinna, a leader. They are from the Abuakwa South Constituency and they are 68 in number.

[Pupils of Ahwenease M/A Basic School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then, we have Baako D/A Basic School, led by Emmanuel Akakpo, a teacher. They are from the Asikuma/Odoben/Brakwa Constituency and are 69 in number.

[Pupils of Baako D/A Basic School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Finally, we have students from the Nursing and Midwifery Training College, led by Ahiatsi Justice Junior, Tertiary Educational Institutions Network (TEIN) President. They are from the Keta Constituency and are 46 in number.

[Students of the Nursing and Midwifery Training College were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: On your behalf, I welcome them to the Parliament of Ghana. I urge them to have a fruitful visit. Kindly resume your seat.

Hon Members, Statement numbered 7 (e), standing in the name of Mr Sebastian Fred Deh, Member of Parliament for Kpando. I am speaking about (e)—it is rather the item numbered 7 (b), which stands in the name of Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah, Member of Parliament for Garu.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I do not know if my Colleagues have copies of the Statement. If you just want us to deal with the one on the console, that is fine.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Are you satisfied?

Mr Shaib: Yes, Mr Speaker, I am all right. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please proceed to deliver your Statement.

STATEMENTS

Closing the Physician Gap in Ghana

Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah (NDC — Garu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make a Statement on closing the physician gap in Ghana, global perspectives and strategic options.

Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to address this House on a matter of urgent national importance: the shortage of health professionals, particularly medical doctors. Across Ghana, many health centres and district hospitals remain critically understaffed. While infrastructure and equipment are vital to a functional health system, the absence of adequate skilled personnel continues to undermine access to quality healthcare. This workforce gap is not merely a structural concern but a direct threat to equitable and effective healthcare delivery in every constituency of our dear nation.

Mr Speaker, nurses who form the backbone of our health system, are still not enough to meet demand. Each year,

we train thousands, yet many remain unemployed because of fiscal constraints, while others leave the country in search of better conditions. Meanwhile, in underserved areas, a few exhausted staff struggle to keep facilities running.

Mr Speaker, the situation is even more serious when it comes to medical doctors. Ghana's physician-to-population ratio currently stands at 2.66 doctors per 10,000 people. The World Health Organization (WTO) recommends at least 10 doctors per 10,000 people. This means that 1 doctor is to 1,000 people, The global average is 17.2 to 10,000 people. This clearly shows how far we must go.

Mr Speaker, according to the Ghana Medical and Dental Council, we have about 12,886 registered medical doctors. To meet the WHO benchmark for a population of about 32 million, Ghana would need roughly 32,000 doctors. That leaves us with a deficit of nearly 19,000 physicians.

Mr Speaker, even if we continue to train about 900 to 1,000 doctors each year, and assume we retain all of them, it would take close to 20 years to close this gap. About 35 per cent of locally trained doctors emigrate annually, seeking better remuneration, working conditions, and professional growth. We are therefore losing a significant portion of the very workforce we invest in training.

Mr Speaker, the imbalance between urban and rural areas worsens the crisis. Some urban facilities have relatively adequate staffing, but many rural districts, including Garu, operate with only one or two doctors serving populations of over 40,000 people. This is not simply inconvenient. It places lives at risk, for the people and one or two doctors who works there.

Mr Speaker, we must also consider the wellbeing of our current workforce. The 2024 performance report of the Medical and Dental Council indicate that nine per cent of doctors cited in professional misconduct cases were found to be dealing with some form of depression. This suggests that beyond the numbers, there is a strain on morale and mental health within the profession.

Mr Speaker, this challenge is serious, but it is not unique to Ghana. Other countries have faced similar shortages and taken bold steps to respond. There are useful lessons we can adopt.

Mr Speaker, some countries have reformed their licensing and examination systems. In Canada, the Medical Council simplified the licensing process for International Medical Graduates by eliminating one of its qualifying exams. Australia has exempted doctors trained in certain comparable systems from additional clinical exams.

2:27 p.m.

Israel has introduced examination waivers for experienced foreign-trained doctors, provided they undergo

structural clinical integration. These reforms have reduced unnecessary barriers while maintaining standards. Ghana can review its own licensure and credentialing recognition frameworks. We should make it easier for Ghanaian doctors abroad to return and practise and for qualified trained doctors to contribute without compromising patient safety. Singapore recently expanded its list of recognised foreign medical degree programmes from 112 to 120 institutions to help address doctor shortage and meet growing health demands. Ghana could consider a similar policy to ease our physician gap while we continue to strengthen local training capacity.

Mr Speaker, secondly, countries such as Canada and Australia have developed practical ready assessment programmes. These allow experienced doctors to undergo supervised clinical practice leading to full licensure. Instead of repeating long training pathways, they are assessed in real practical settings. Israel has similarly replaced lengthy internship requirements for some foreign-trained doctors with structured integration schemes. Today, international medical graduates make up to a significant share of their physician workforce. Ghana can explore similar supervised fast-track pathways to get doctors come to Ghana.

Mr Speaker, thirdly, several countries align immigration policies with health workforce needs. They provide expedited visa processing, relocation support, and incentive for doctors who

agree to work in underserved areas. We can design targets, recruitment strategies, and prioritise deprived districts.

Mr Speaker, Malaysia addressed its health workforce shortages by reforming medical education, shifting from outcome-based to competitive-based medical education. The country emphasised clinical competence and introduced flexible postgraduate pathways while upholding national standards, thereby expanding training capabilities and capacities without compromising quality.

Mr Speaker, based on these lessons, I propose a multi-pronged national strategy: one, adopting competency-based medical education in all medical training institutions; two, introduce flexible parallel postgraduate training pathways to expand specialist training; three, reform licensure and credential recognition to attract foreign-trained Ghanaian doctors and qualified international medical graduates; four, align immigration and health policies to recruit doctors for underserved areas; and five, invest in the faculty development, infrastructure and regulate capacity to retain qualified doctors.

Mr Speaker, at the same time, we must improve working conditions, ensure fair, timely compensation, provide rural incentives, and strengthen mental health support for health professionals who work in Ghana.

Expanding the number without adding welfare will not solve the problem.

Mr Speaker, achieving Universal Health Coverage by 2030 depends on the strength of our human resource for health. No health system can function without the adequate number of motivated and well-trained doctors and nurses. Let us all, therefore, approach this issue with the urgency it deserves. The people of Garu, Gomoa, Ga Mashie and every community in Ghana deserve accessible and quality health care so that we can achieve the 2030 Universal Health Coverage as we all seek to.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to read this Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that is the Statement ably made. I will give the floor to Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the very important and insightful Statement made by my Hon Friend, Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah, the MP for Garu.

Mr Speaker, I think the maker of the Statement ought to be commended for tabling such an important matter on the Floor of Parliament. He underscores the importance of health care, and indeed, the common statement is that a healthy nation is a wealthy nation, and across the world, as he pointed out and referred to Malaysia and other parts of the world

where they have been very successful at constructing a robust public health system which supports their population and which makes their population productive and effective.

Mr Speaker, some of the recommendations he made are most welcome and are to be worked on. There are one or two other contributions I believe will further enrich the recommendations the maker of the Statement put forward. He talks about physicians and went into great detail in dissecting the sector into the segment of medical doctors, nurses, the shortfall we have, the numbers we need, the measures we ought to put in place to attract them, to retain them, and to avoid a situation where our health care professionals are posted to the right places of our country for them to be able to meet the health care needs of our compatriots.

Mr Speaker, take, for example, the nursing field. Today, statistics tell us that as at October 2025, there are 13,500 nurses who have not been posted; 13,500 nurses who have not been posted. They have been trained. The country has spent money on training them. They are equipped, willing to work, and yet they have not been posted as of October 2025. As we speak, we do not have budgetary provision for recruiting these health care workers who have been trained and are willing to work but as we speak today, are literally languishing in their homes and do not have postings. I think we need to pay attention to that and prioritise the

recruitment of nurses across our country in order to augment the effectiveness of the health care system of our country.

Mr Speaker, again, the Upper West Regional Director of the Ghana Health Service had cause to indicate that as of December 2025, 80 per cent of doctors were posted to the Upper West Region of our country did not report to duty. That is a major cause for concern. Indeed, this is not peculiar to the Upper West Region. In my own home region, the Savannah Region, we have similar situations where doctors are posted and they do not report to duty. We need to interrogate the reasons for this. It certainly will be a question of conditions of service and the nature of the environment they are posted to. All of these will have to be looked at.

Mr Speaker, again, as we speak today, nurses in the public service of our country who have been recruited, have not been paid salary for 14 months. If we are going to build a robust public health system for our country, these are matters we have to prioritise where when nurses are recruited, they are paid. Not only do we have 13,500 nurses who have been trained, equipped, ready and willing to work, not being recruited, but even those who have been recruited, 14,000 of them, a good number of them, are working as we speak, and yet for 14 months they have not been paid.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by saying that there is really a part of the public health system of our country

which I believe the authorities ought to pay attention to.

2:37 p.m.

Mr Speaker, by that I refer to Agenda 111 and it is arguably the most revolutionary, the most audacious, the most expansive and the most transformative intervention in the public health system of our country since independence. What is Agenda 111? —

Mr Speaker, I did not know we were being timed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But the rules have been in existence for a long time that comments on a Statement should not exceed five minutes?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, if you could give me 30 seconds to conclude.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No. With all due respect, I beg you. We have since been going in accordance with the time. I will give the Floor to Hon Nawaane.

Hon Dr Nawaane, you have the floor.

Dr Mark Kurt Nawaane (NDC — Nabdam): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. Before I give my submission, I want to correct one fact. The previous speaker said that 13,500 nurses are unemployed. I think that is factually wrong. The 13,500 nurses were employed before the

National Democratic Congress (NDC) came to power and they were not paid. As we speak now, they are being paid. So, that is not correct. *[Interruption]* Yes, the 13,500 nurses are those who have been paid.

Mr Speaker, the issue of inadequate doctors or a lack of enough doctors is something that, as a nation, we need to take radical steps to see to what extent we can correct it. As we speak now, on the Medical and Dental Council Register, we have about 13,000 doctors. But from the Statement, we would realise that we need about 32,000 doctors. That is almost about 300 per cent of that number. And apart from that, there is what we call distribution. Distribution is skewed towards the big towns. Accra and Kumasi alone take about 70 per cent of those few doctors. The remaining doctors are now supposed to go to the smaller towns. So, we have a situation where the doctor-to-patient ratio in Accra is about 1 to 1,200. But when we take the Oti Region for example, the ratio stands at 1 to 22,000, which is not good for a nation such as Ghana. Now, what can we do about it? Even as we speak, we have doctors who have not been employed. But what can we do about it?

Currently, we need to increase the production of doctors. There are so many medical faculties that are springing up and the problem is payment. So, what I recommend to the Government is that instead of sponsoring people outside to go and do medicine, they should invest

that amount of money to give scholarships to students to study those courses in Ghana here. A case is that of Entrance University. Entrance University has a medical degree course, but the number of students they admit is just between 10 and 20 students and that is too small. If the Government can give scholarships to very brilliant students to choose these schools and allow more medical schools to be opened, we can do it. It is something that we can do and this will increase the number of doctors.

The other problem is that, as a nation, we should look at the complementary efforts of the private sector. As we speak, there are a lot of job opportunities in the private sector. There are about 3,000 private hospitals in the country, which can employ more people. But we are to some extent, leaving them aside. This is unemployment that we are talking about. If we look at the situation very well, and if they could go to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Your time is up.

Yes, Hon Tampuli, you are on the floor.

Mr Alhassan Tampuli Sulemana (NPP — Gushegu): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to the Statement that has been ably made by Hon Dr Thomas Anabah. The Statement was very well delivered and absolutely

very well researched. If I look at the references, it tells me that he did quite good research.

Mr Speaker, this situation that we are complaining about is not a problem of today. It has been with us for God knows how long. This matter, I believe, if we come back next year, God willing, we shall be talking about it again and we shall be doing so for the next 10 years.

Mr Speaker, we should be talking about solutions at this stage and not rehashing the problems that all of us know. The issue about the number of medical professionals who have not been hired and are still waiting at home to be employed is even more than 50,000. We are not talking about only nurses, but we are talking about other medical professionals and that is above 50,000. Some of them are sitting at home looking for an opportunity to serve their nation and to serve us.

Mr Speaker, that is where the point about Agenda 111 comes to bear. One of the most revolutionary initiatives since independence is the Agenda 111 initiative. Never has there been any audacious move to do—in fact, it is even Agenda 112. At the time that we were doing Agenda 111, we had not even considered Karaga. In due course, Karaga was added, so it became 112. But Mr Speaker, sadly, when we move around the sites of these Agenda 111 facilities, we would find out that some of them are already in ruin. The facilities

which are 60 per cent, 70 per cent, 40 per cent and different stages of completion have been abandoned. How do we expand healthcare facilities and abandon some of these construction sites?

Mr Speaker, one of the most difficult situations for the health sector is clearance from the Ministry of Finance. That is the elephant in the room and we must say it loudly. The Minister for Finance has to give them clearance for them to be able to recruit. *Na sika no wɔhe?*

Mr Speaker, so we need to find ways to deal with this situation and the solution is not far from us. The solution is right in front of us. We can use the 1-3-3 formula, the 24-Hour Economy formula. The nurses and other health professionals who are at home will come for six hours and others will come for another six hours and then we will be giving meaning to the 24-Hour Economy.

So, Mr Speaker, let us bring to bear the 1-3-3 formula. The youth of Ghana need work. They are prepared; they are schooled and they need work. Let us give them the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, let us not come here next year to lament and lament. The solution is there; expand the health infrastructure, the Ministry of Finance should give financial clearance, all these people will be working and we will not come back here to talk about the same situation.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much.

2:47 p.m.

Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment (Dr Abdul-Rashid Hassan Pelpuo) (MP): Mr Speaker, I want to thank the maker of this Statement for this very thoughtful Statement he has made, because health is a critical issue and affects everybody. Where health facilities exist and the practitioners are not available, especially nurses and doctors, is a serious concern that we will all have to express. I do admit that this is a long-lasting issue. It was not just something we woke up to meet. It has been there for a while. There must be a national commitment to solve the problem, a policy direction from government to government that should tackle the issue, provide the needed response to the need for nurses, engagement of doctors, and to the effect that we have a total approach to our health needs.

Mr Speaker, the challenge, which was also mentioned by Hon Member for Damongo, Mr Samuel Jinapor, is that we have the challenge of nurses not being employed, doctors not being employed adequately, but we also have a challenge of those employed who refuse to work. I have always cited the example that years ago, the colonial masters travelled all the way from the United Kingdom to Ghana. They were posted to places as far as the Tumu and beyond, and to everywhere else in Ghana. They travelled there and

they worked. Today, they post people to Wa—Seventeen nurses were posted to Wa last year, and they refused to go. Meanwhile, there is a Hippocratic Oath, which they have admitted before they were pronounced doctors, to abide by and to make manifest in their life as professionals.

So, Mr Speaker, while we are urging that this policy be attended to—I listened to the speaker talk about the reason being that physical policy approach does not support engagement of everybody we have employed. I do admit to that. But it is important also for those who are available to take a decision and work wherever they are posted. A place like Wa, it is surprising when they refuse to go there. There are three universities there. There are very good secondary schools there. There are excellent basic schools there. Life there is good, food is cheap, yet they refuse to go. What explanations can they give to the people of Ghana?

Mr Speaker, I have heard a lot of talk about Agenda 111. I listened to Hon Tampuli, when he repeated the point the Hon Member for Damongo was making on the Agenda 111. Mr Speaker, it has to be understood very clearly. The issue is not about the number of health posts in Ghana. In fact, we have built several of them all over the country. That is the reason why the people are there, and we are urging that they should be employed. We have lots of community health centres all throughout the country, built

by the National Democratic Congress (NDC). We did not even mention the concepts, the Community Health Planning Services (CHPS) compounds. They are all over. The issue is not about the availability that we are talking about or that they are talking about. The issue is about the availability of the doctors and our commitment to pay them and get them employed.

We are saying that within the period we are in, we have demonstrated we can do that. There was a leftover of about 12,000 workers who were not paid, though employed. As soon as we came, we started paying them. So, I was surprised when Hon Jinapor said they are not being paid. There was an approval of the payment by the Minister for Finance, and then along the line, payments are being made.

Mr Speaker, I also think that this issue must not be a political issue. We need to commit ourselves to it. I believe that this Statement will be an awakening call for us to have proper attention to it and deal with it comprehensively.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leadership?

Hon Members, we have nine Statements to take. The practice that we have adopted is that when we take two each, then we come to Leadership. We have nine Statements per the Order Paper.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I was respectfully going to seek your permission just to indulge us to take just one more on each Side. Mr Speaker, you can see that this Statement is of a very important—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is that the sense of the House?

Hon Members, let us bear. Every day we come and we talk about backlog of Statements. We complain about backlog of Statements and then—What is the sense of the House?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, that is alright. At least, it is clear my Colleague did not yield. It is alright. I will yield to my Friend over there.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leadership is yielding to you. Your time starts now.

Mr Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, I commend the maker of the Statement. Historically, our problem as a nation was brain drain in the health sector. Today, we are not complaining of brain drain. We are rather complaining of not being able to hire more doctors, more physicians, more nurses, and more healthcare professionals. Mr Speaker, the question is why?

At this point, we may want to take a historical journey as to how governments have solved some of the problems we

have faced in our health sector. Mr Speaker, not long ago, I stated that historically, our problem was brain drain. When President Kufuor took office in the year 2001, these are some of the interventions he introduced to solve some of the problems we had in the sector, the brain drain in the health sector. He introduced extra duty allowance to help our doctors earn more money. He gave them concessions in respect of import duty at the port. He also introduced the National Health Insurance Scheme to help generate more revenue in the sector to take care of expenditure in the sector, with the ripple effect of having more money in the pockets of our health sector professionals to care for brain drain.

Mr Speaker, today, we have been given a mandate of 88 Members of Parliament. About 57 per cent of Ghanaians voted for the NDC to make very bold decisions. If there is a problem, this is not the time for lamentation. It is the time for solutions. So fix it. Fix the problems and not come here to lament. The Statements are riddled with lamentations.

Mr Speaker, they inherited Agenda 111. Continue with it. It was a brilliant initiative by the Nana Akufo-Addo's administration, Nana Addo Dankwa – Dr Bawumia administration. The implementation was with the taxpayers' money. Let us give value and meaning to the taxpayers' money. Fix it so that our physicians will have a place to work. Fix it.

Mr Speaker, in this year's Budget, an amount of GH¢100 million was allocated to the Agenda 111 programme while they allocated GH¢200 million for sanitary pads. The problem is a matter of your policy choices. It is not a country that is helpless. It is a problem of wrong priorities of the NDC Government. They can fix it with their Budget, instead of reading Statements on the floor of Parliament and lamenting. The book of lamentations has already been written. The Bible does not expect the addition of any book of lamentations by the NDC Government. If there is a problem, they should fix it.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leadership? You are yielding to Dr Sandaare.

2:57 p.m.

Dr Sebastian Ngmenenso Sandaare (NDC — Daffiama/Bussie/Issa): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. I thank the maker of the Statement for this very important national issue on how we have inequitable distribution of our health workers, nurses and doctors and other health workers.

Mr Speaker, this is one of the issues that we need to discuss without being partisan. It is an issue that, as a House, we have to come together and find solutions to. The problems of health

workers did not start today. It has been there over the years. I remember when I started as a medical officer, the issue of doctors not accepting posting and not being motivated was there. It has been with us as an issue; therefore, we must come together to discuss the solutions. In this country, the issue is not about trainings or postings. It is, just like the maker of this Statement said, about ensuring equitable distribution of our doctors, nurses and other health workers.

One of the Hon Members who contributed to the Statement gave evidence of where in Accra the doctor-to-population ratio is about 1 is to 1,000. We get to a region like Oti Region or my region; I have a doctor-to-patient ratio being 1 is to 22,000. So, the question we ask is, why? Why is it that doctors would want to remain in Accra and would not want to go to Oti or go to the Upper West Region or any other rural region? It has to do with motivation. Because the doctors who work in the cities make extra income and have other opportunities.

So, what we need to do and discuss is to ensure that we put incentives in place, so that the doctor posted to the Upper West Region or posted to Oti Region would have equal opportunities or fair opportunities like the one working in Accra. The doctors that were posted to Upper West Region, Upper East Region who refused to go did so because they look at it and they do not have

motivational packages over there. Same applies to the nurses and other health workers.

Sometimes, even before they are posted, they are already working in private health facilities. So, if a doctor already, after completing, is working in a private facility in Accra, and we post him to Upper West or Upper East, he compares working in that private facility and going to the rural area and what is in there for him? So, we have to look at the distribution, the motivation, and also addressing the environmental factors. Are there the needed equipment where the doctor or nurse is posted? Is the facility enabling so that this doctor or nurse can stay and work? That is where all of us have responsibilities. As Members of Parliament, we can look at what can we do in our individual capacity to ensure that a doctor or a nurse is comfortable in our district.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, the issue is not about Agenda 111. So, we should not introduce any Agenda 111 in this national issue. It is not about the health facilities. I am saying that the issue is not about the number of hospitals that are in the country. It is about the fact that the facilities even exist, but the people are not accepting posting to these areas. They brought their Agenda 111, a populist issue, that created problems for them, so anything we want to discuss here, even if it has nothing to do with Agenda 111, they bring Agenda 111 into it.

Mr Speaker, Government is enabling measures to ensure that our health workers accept posting to these areas. By that I mean, Government is retooling—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. That brings us to the end of that Statement. We would move to the Statement numbered (c), standing in the name of Hon Charles Asiedu, Member of Parliament for Tano South.

Urgent Need to Revitalise the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company Ltd

Mr Charles Asiedu (NDC — Tano South): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, it is with a good sense of duty that I rise to deliver this Statement on a matter of utmost national importance. My Statement is on the urgent need to revitalise the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company Limited. The Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company is a state-owned enterprise that plays a central role in the area of Liquefied Petroleum Gas promotion. Its core mandate is to produce and distribute safe, affordable Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) cylinders, cookware, and related accessories, for domestic consumption and export.

Let us note that promoting the use of LPG is a key component of Ghana's

strategy for environmental protection, sustainable energy use and climate change mitigation. The adoption of LPG reduces reliance on firewood and charcoal in order to preserve our forest reserves, improve indoor air quality and reduce greenhouse gas emissions. According to the 2023 Industry Report of the Ghana Chamber of Bulk Oil Distributors, LPG forms the primary cooking fuel for about 40 per cent of Ghanaians. The country has also set an ambitious target to achieve 50 per cent LPG penetration by 2030.

Globally, the drift towards clean cooking solutions is accelerating. The Clean Cooking Alliance notes that while only 60 per cent of the world's population had access to clean cooking in 2010, this figure had improved to nearly 75 per cent by 2024. However, over 2 billion people still cook with smoky and inefficient fuels and stoves. Ghana cannot afford to fall behind in this global shift. In rural Ghana, LPG usage only formed 17 per cent of total fuel usage in 2023.

Mr Speaker, despite the strategic relevance of the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company to lead the way in LPG promotion, it has struggled to fulfil its potential. The Auditor-General's report revealed that the company posted a loss of GH¢4 million in 2021. In 2023, the company was acquired by the Ghana Gas Company Limited in a bid to rescue it from operational collapse. Even though this

acquisition signals a step in the right direction, there is an urgent need for a broader and more coordinated national recovery plan. In this regard, the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition had announced earlier this year the establishment of a Joint Project Implementation Committee to oversee a revitalisation plan. This is welcoming. But further measures must be considered.

I propose the following as additional pathways for the company's recovery. One: The state must inject targeted capital to upgrade the company's production lines, introduce modern fabrication technologies and improve quality control processes. Two: We must engage a lot of private investors and LPG marketing companies in joint ventures that can improve efficiency, expand access to the market and also boost innovation. Three: Government and public institutions should be encouraged to source their LPG products and accessories from the company as a matter of policy.

3:07 p.m.

Four: Mr Speaker, the company should be supported under the African Continental Free Trade Area to enter neighbouring markets by leveraging the regional demand for clean cooking solutions. Again, the public needs to be constantly sensitised about the health, economic, and environmental benefits of LPG usage. Let us remember that a stronger demand will sustain the

operations of the company. Mr Speaker, finally, let us strengthen performance-based accountability mechanisms within all state-owned enterprises, including the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company, to ensure transparency and accountability.

To conclude, Mr Speaker, the call to revitalise the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company is not only about rescuing an ailing company. It is also about fortifying Ghana's clean energy transition by reducing carbon footprints and improving public health. The Clean Cooking Alliance has estimated that universal access to clean cooking could reduce global carbon emissions by 1.5 gigatons by 2030. Mr Speaker, this is equivalent to the emissions from all the planes that fly in our skies and all the ships that sail on our oceans every year. This is an important opportunity for Ghana to lead by example in West Africa. A revitalised Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company will empower local industry, create jobs, expand LPG access, and support Ghana's climate goals. I therefore call on this House to support the revitalisation efforts with the urgency and seriousness they deserve.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that is the statement ably made. It is now time to take comments. Is anybody going to comment from my left Side?

You have the floor.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by my Colleague, Hon Charles Asiedu, Member of Parliament for Tano South. Mr Speaker, it is a very timely call for us as Members of Parliament because of the need to improve our usage of LPG in our homes. As the statistics show, a lot of homes in Ghana are not using LPG, though in the urban areas, predominantly within the Greater Accra, Ashanti, Western Regions, amongst others, we have high usage of LPG. The total population of Ghana who use LPG is quite low, and that means a lot of people are using fossil fuels, such as charcoal, amongst others, which is not good for our environment.

So, how do we equip and resource the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company to perform that role and function? As indicated, over the past years, the Company has not been doing well in terms of its books because government has not released adequate funding to support its corporate objectives and goals. So, my clarion call to the Government is that this is an important state asset, and as we try to leverage the Ghana National Gas Limited Company (GNGLC) to absorb them and then support them, GNGLC itself has been suffering. GNGLC has not gotten its own statutory mandate; it does not have its own Act that governs its rules. So, on what basis and how well are they going to take care of the needs of Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company? I believe that we need to look beyond GNGLC as a supporting arm for

Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company. It should be an intentional Government policy; there should be an intentional Government budgetary allocation to support Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company so that they will deliver on the numbers that we need in Ghana.

Ghana has a lot of space to improve its climate conditions. Ghana has a lot of space to improve the use of LPG as against the use of fossil fuels, such as charcoal, among others. The only way to mitigate that effect is to ensure that Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company is adequately supported, and we can support them with budgetary allocation. The Ministry of Finance should find the necessary money to support them. The Ministry of Energy and Green Transition should also give them the needed support and cooperation, since the Ministry has Green Transition attached to it, and the Green Transition can be successfully done if we are able to support Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company.

My call to Ghanaians, the entire nation, is that we should have a look at improving the use of LPG. In the rural communities, how do we ensure that we give them access to cylinders? Will the Government even subsidise the cylinders for them so that more people will be attracted to use them in our homes? I think this is a bigger conversation that, as a country, we need to look into. And so, Mr Speaker, without more, I want to thank the maker of the Statement for bringing this important Statement up. In fact, I will go to the extent of urging Mr

Speaker to refer this particular Statement to the Committee on Energy, and then the Ministry of Finance to work collaboratively. The Minister of Energy and Green Transition has just walked in. We are talking about the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company; he should please support them. Let us improve climate change, and let us make sure that Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company performs its work dutifully.

Mr Speaker, without more, I want to thank you for the opportunity.

Minister for Energy and Green Transition (Mr John A. Jinapor) (MP): Mr Speaker, let me thank you very much, and I would like to commend the maker of the Statement even though I do not know him—*[Laughter]*—And I can just hazard a guess that it is only Hon Charles Asiedu who will make this brilliant Statement. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I must be honest, I just walked in and heard Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company. And being my passion, I thought that I should seek permission from you to make a few remarks. Mr Speaker, I would want to dwell on Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company without taking too much time. My office has been working with the National Petroleum Authority (NPA), of which my elder Brother headed before, and GNGLC to revamp Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company. I can confirm that, so far, the estimate shows that they need about US\$8 million to be able to

revamp it. We have been able to mobilise about US\$6 million for them, and the retooling is going on.

In fact, if you look at what they have produced this year, it is more than double of what happened in 2024. So, we are on course to revamp Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company, and we are on course to retool it. Not only are we doing that, but we are giving them off-taker agreements and setting up an escrow account. As part of the cylinder recirculation model, as Minister, I have issued a directive that we recall all the old and obsolete cylinders so that Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company would retrofit them and make them useful. Also, we have signed an agreement with Goil PLC so that they will be the off-taker for the cylinders as part of Ghana Cylinder Recirculation Model.

And so, Mr Speaker, let me assure this House that we are on course towards retooling Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company and making it a modern factory fit for purpose. What we intend to do is to eventually ban the importation of cylinders and insist that all these cylinders and canisters ought to be procured here in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, I am very grateful for giving me this opportunity. Thank you very much.

Mr Alhassan Tampuli Sulemana (NPP — Gushegu): Mr Speaker, I appreciate the opportunity to give some reflections on the Statement ably made by my very good Friend, Hon Charles

Asiedu. Mr Speaker, I feel very compelled to share some perspective on this subject matter, having regard to the fact that I was once the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the regulator of the downstream petroleum industry, and then we did quite a lot of things to bring back the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company. Mr Speaker, at some point, we had to support them financially to be able to get them to take care of some of their recurrent expenditure.

In fact, Mr Speaker, the fulcrum around which the cylinder recirculation model of LPG distribution was built was around Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company, so that they will be producing the cylinders. Mr Speaker, at some point, it became so obvious that they did not even have the capacity to produce the number of cylinders that we needed in the country, and we had to go on tours across the world to be able to get some partnership with Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company so that they would be able to get the cylinders.

3:17 p.m.

So, we even introduced a margin in the price build-up of the LPG so that we would be able to use that to procure cylinders on a large scale and to build their capacity. In fact, we even thought at some point that the current location of GCMC on the Spintex Road has outlived the usefulness for which it was sited there. Back in the days, the entire Spintex Road was almost like an industrial enclave. Today, there are a lot of residencies and commercial facilities. So, we proposed at some point to move

the company to the industrial enclaves so that the company will be able to expand. As it is now, its location makes it not expandable.

So, Mr Speaker, the key drivers of getting this thing done is underpinned by three As, as we call them: affordability, accessibility, and availability of LPG so that we would be able to do cylinder circulation model across the country. Across the sub-region, it is only in Ghana that we currently have this model where we have bullets sitting in residential areas and people filling their cylinders, and sometimes there is a blast. Examples abound. Mr Speaker, when you go to Togo, Benin, Cote d'Ivoire, Burkina Faso, and all across the sub-region, nobody does what we are doing. They all have cylinder recirculation model; you pick up a pre-filled cylinder, you pay, and you give them an empty one. Any time you have need for more LPG, you just go and swap an empty cylinder for a pre-filled one. And we think that that is a better arrangement and it can only be done if we give Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company the commanding heights of that industry so that they expand and create more jobs. In any case, I am sure that it will be a good example where we can implement the 24-Hour Economy where they work three shifts for one job in 24 hours.

Mr Speaker, they have that capacity to do this and I think that the maker of the Statement got this spot on and this House has to support this initiative. I am

happy the Minister himself is here; over to him. We are looking at how he is going to make this happen and then we support him from this House.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I think we can proceed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Majority?

That marks the end of commentary on that Statement. The next Statement stands in the name of Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah, Member of Parliament for Old Tafo.

Very well, in his absence, I direct that the Statement be published in the *Hansard*.

The Need to Prioritise the Completion and Optimal Utilisation of Existing Sports Infrastructure before Initiating New Projects

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP — Old Tafo): Mr Speaker, I make this Statement on the urgent need for the Ministry of Sports and Recreation to prioritise the completion, rehabilitation, and effective utilisation of ongoing and stalled sports infrastructure projects across the country before embarking on new construction commitments.

Mr Speaker, over the past decade, Ghana has witnessed a commendable effort toward expanding its sports infrastructure base. From the construction of the ten Youth Resource Centres initiated under the previous administration, to regional sports complexes in Nyinahin, Dunkwa-on-Offin, and Ho, as well as the refurbishment of existing stadia in Cape Coast, Tamale, and Accra, these projects were intended to democratise access to sports facilities and nurture talent development at the grassroots level.

However, Mr Speaker, a significant number of these projects remain. Nyinahin and Nkawkaw Sports Complexes, as well as several of the Youth Resource Centres, have stalled at various stages due to funding gaps, lack of coordination, or shifting ministerial priorities. These incomplete facilities represent not only sunk public investments but also lost opportunities for young athletes, local sports associations, and communities whose economic and social wellbeing could have been improved through active sports participation.

Mr Speaker, it is against this backdrop that the recent announcement by the Hon Minister for Sports and Recreation, outlining plans to construct seven new stadia and establish permanent camping and training bases for our national teams in 2026, must be viewed with cautious optimism. While the ambition to expand our sports infrastructure is laudable, the Ministry must not allow the allure of new projects

to overshadow the unfinished business of completing those that have already consumed significant national resources.

Therefore, Mr Speaker, I wish to make the following recommendations for the consideration of this House and the Ministry:

- i. **Comprehensive Audit and Assessment:** The Ministry of Sports and Recreation should undertake a nationwide audit of all ongoing and incomplete sports infrastructure projects. This audit must detail the current status, outstanding works, financial commitments, and estimated costs to complete each facility.
- ii. **Prioritised Completion Plan:** Based on the audit, a clear completion plan should be developed and presented to Parliament, indicating timelines and funding sources. The completion of ongoing projects must take precedence over the initiation of new ones, to ensure value for money and prevent resource wastage.
- iii. **Integrated Infrastructure Strategy:** The Ministry should develop a National Sports Infrastructure Development Plan that aligns existing and new projects under a coherent strategy, ensuring regional balance, sustainability, and

equitable access to facilities for all Ghanaians.

iv. development should be submitted to Parliament, accompanied by independent monitoring and evaluation mechanisms to track physical and financial progress, and ensure that future projects avoid the pitfalls of stalled execution.

Mr Speaker, as a nation seeking to position sports as a tool for youth empowerment, job creation, and national unity, we cannot afford a cycle of abandoned projects and short-lived initiatives. The sustainability of our sports ecosystem depends not on the quantity of projects announced, but on the quality, functionality, and consistency of our investments.

Ghana's young athletes deserve facilities that are safe, accessible, and conducive to excellence. Our communities deserve infrastructure that generates social and economic dividends. Our taxpayers deserve accountability for every cedi invested in the name of sports development.

Mr Speaker, I therefore call on the Ministry to exercise prudent judgment and strategic foresight by ensuring that all existing projects are completed, operationalised, and maintained before any new major projects are commenced. Only then can we build a sports infrastructure legacy that is sustainable, inclusive, and truly in the national interest.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

[Published by Order of Mr Speaker]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the next Statement stands in the name of Mr Sebastian Fred Deh, Member of Parliament for Kpando.

Supporting Smallholder Farmers in Ghana: The Role of Financial Inclusion and Institutions with Tailor-Made Innovative Financial Intermediation

Mr Sebastian Fred Deh (NDC — Kpando): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I rise to make this Statement in support of smallholder farmers in Ghana, the role of financial institutions with tailor-made, innovative financial intermediation. Mr Speaker, I also want to use the opportunity to thank you so much for admitting this Statement months back. But because of the lapse of time, I will abridge it and with your leave, ask that the entire Statement as submitted and admitted by your good self be published in the *Hansard*.

Introduction

Mr Speaker, I rise today to draw attention to the critical importance of supporting the smallholder farmers in Ghana, who form the backbone of our agricultural sector. Agriculture employs over half of our population and contributes significantly to Ghana's Gross Domestic Product (GDP). Despite their crucial role, smallholder farmers

remain among the most economically vulnerable in our society.

Mr Speaker, today I wish to emphasise the need for a strategic, well-coordinated approach to supporting the smallholder farmers, with particular focus on the role of financial inclusion, using Opportunity International Savings and Loans (OISL) as a shining example of how targeted financial services can transform the agricultural landscape and improve the lives of our farmers.

The Significance of Smallholder Farmers in Ghana's Economy

Mr Speaker, it is well-documented that smallholder farmers constitute about 70 per cent of Ghana's farming population, producing a majority of our staple foods such as maize, cassava, yams, and vegetables. They play a vital role in ensuring food security, reducing rural poverty, and supporting our overall economic development.

However, smallholder farmers face numerous challenges including limited access to affordable credit, inadequate extension services, poor market linkages, climate change, and post-harvest losses. Addressing these challenges holistically is necessary if we are to achieve food self-sufficiency and sustainable rural development as country.

The Financial Inclusion Gap

Mr Speaker, access to finance is one of the biggest barriers to the growth and prosperity of smallholder farmers. Many of our farmers, particularly those in

remote areas, remain excluded from the formal financial system. Without access to affordable loans, savings products, and insurance, farmers are unable to invest in improved seeds, fertilisers, mechanisation, and post-harvest infrastructure.

According to the 2021 Global Findex Report, rural populations in Ghana remain underserved by financial institutions. This financial exclusion reduces productivity and exacerbates poverty.

The Role of Opportunity International Savings and Loans

Mr Speaker, one institution that has taken deliberate steps to bridge this financial inclusion gap for smallholder farmers is Opportunity International Savings and Loans (OISL) and other similar financial institutions. Opportunity International has been operating in Ghana for over 20 years, offering innovative financial products tailored to the needs of smallholder farmers, agribusinesses, and micro-entrepreneurs.

Opportunity International's agricultural finance programmes adopt the value chain financing approach and are focus on:

- Providing seasonal loans to farmers to purchase inputs at the start of the planting season.
- Offering financial literacy training to ensure farmers understand basic financial

management, savings, and loan repayment strategies.

- Facilitating linkages with buyers and input suppliers, thereby integrating farmers into value chains.
- Offering mobile banking services to rural farmers, allowing them to save and transact without traveling long distances.

Mr Speaker, this combination of credit, training, and market linkages has helped thousands of smallholder farmers improve their productivity and incomes.

Case Studies and Success Stories

Mr Speaker, let me share the story of Ama Mensah, a maize farmer in the Bono Region. Through Opportunity International, Ama received her first-ever agricultural loan in 2020, which she used to purchase improved seeds, fertilisers, and hire a tractor for ploughing. In addition to the loan, Ama benefited from training on good agricultural practices and financial management. Ama's case is similar to Akua Agbledela from Kudzra in Kpando in the Volta Region and Kofi Osei of Aboatoase in the Oti Region of Ghana. Mr Speaker, Ama's maize yield increased by 70 per cent after adopting modern farming practices, and with improved market access facilitated by Opportunity International, she was able to sell her produce at competitive prices.

3:27 p.m.

Today, Ama is not only feeding her family, but is saving to expand her farm and her children's school fees. Mr Speaker, there are countless similar stories across the country—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Second Deputy Speaker to take the Chair.

3:28 p.m. — [HON SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR ANDREW ASIAMAH AMOAKO, IN THE CHAIR]

Mr Deh: There are countless similar stories across the country, demonstrating that when smallholder farmers have access to the right financial tools, training, and market opportunities, they can transform their lives and contribute meaningfully to Ghana's development.

Policy Recommendations to Scale Support for Smallholder Farmers

Mr Speaker, while institutions like Opportunity International are playing a commendable role, we, as policymakers, must create an enabling environment to scale these efforts and ensure that financial inclusion for smallholder farmers becomes a national priority. I propose the following:

a) Establishment of an Agricultural Finance Support Fund

A dedicated fund of this nature would de-risk lending to smallholder farmers by providing credit guarantees to financial institutions that offer loans to

farmers. This would incentivise more banks and non-bank financial institutions to develop innovative, low-interest agricultural loan products. The role of Ghana Incentive-Based Risk-Sharing System for Agricultural Lending (GIRSAL) is acknowledged here, and should be scaled further

b) Strengthen Public-Private Partnerships

Mr Speaker, strong Public-Private Partnerships (PPP) are essential for delivering comprehensive support to smallholder farmers. Government extension services, agribusinesses, and financial institutions must work together in a concerted manner to bundle finance, training, inputs, and market access into integrated support packages for farmers.

c) Digital Financial Services Expansion

Mr Speaker, the rapid adoption of mobile money in Ghana presents a tremendous opportunity to expand digital financial services to rural farmers. It is critical for financial institutions to invest in developing mobile-based savings, loans, and insurance products tailored to farmers' needs.

d) Farmer Database and Credit Scoring System

The Government, through the Ministry of Food and Agriculture, should develop a national database of smallholder farmers, including their crops, farm sizes, and production histories. This would enable financial

institutions to develop customised products and improve credit assessments, thereby reducing the risk premium on agricultural loans.

e) Climate-Smart Financing

Mr Speaker, climate change poses an existential threat to smallholder agriculture. We must encourage climate-smart agricultural practices through targeted financing mechanisms, such as subsidised loans for climate-resilient seeds, irrigation systems, and solar-powered equipment.

Inclusion of Women and Youth

Mr Speaker, we cannot overlook the critical role of women and youth in agriculture. Women constitute the majority of smallholder farmers, yet they face greater barriers to accessing finance. Special attention must be paid to developing gender-sensitive financial products and providing training tailored to the needs of women farmers. Furthermore, attracting youth to agriculture requires innovative financing models that combine capital, technology, and entrepreneurship support to make farming a viable and attractive livelihood for the next generation can add great value to deepening financial intermediation for small holder farmers.

Coordinating Policy Interventions

Mr Speaker, in consideration, the critical challenges confronting small holder farmers are cross cutting and manifest across various sectors of agriculture. It is imperative that

programmes are designed to dovetail into activities of the smallholder farmer for better impact. It is in this light that the current Government's Flagship programme for agriculture dubbed the Feed Ghana Programme deserves commendation. This elaborate programme being rolled out by Government has almost all 6 components focused on the smallholder farmer and are coordinated from a single point of view. I use this opportunity to enumerate them:

- Grains and Legumes Development

- Vegetable Development Project

- Livestock Development Project

- Poultry Revitalisation Efforts

- Controlled Environment Farming

- Urban and Peri-Urban Agriculture

Measuring Impact

Mr Speaker, it is essential that we track the impact of financial inclusion programmes targeted at smallholder farmers. I propose that the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Food and Agriculture develop key performance indicators (KPIs) to measure the number of farmers accessing formal financial services, the volume of agricultural loans

disbursed, and the repayment rates. These indicators should be reported annually to Parliament, enabling us to assess progress and refine policies where necessary.

Conclusion

Mr Speaker, supporting smallholder farmers is not just an agricultural policy matter — it is a national development imperative. By ensuring that our farmers have access to the financial tools, training, and markets they need, we are investing in food security, poverty reduction, and economic development. Institutions like Opportunity International Savings and Loans have demonstrated that with the right support, smallholder farmers can thrive. Mr Speaker, I believe this is embedded in the vision of President John Dramani Mahama agricultural development and should therefore be encouraged for it will empower our farmers, strengthen our rural economies, and ensure a more prosperous and food-secure Ghana.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, I think the rules have already been set. We are going to have two contributors from each Side and the time is five minutes. So, we will begin from Hon Samuel Awuku, Member for Akuapem North. Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP — Akuapem North): Mr Speaker, also permit me to break protocol by extending my deepest condolences to you.

Mr Speaker, listening to the Hon Member of Parliament and the maker of this Statement, I would like to commend him for bringing the plight and the issues of our farmers, and especially, those who practice farming, not on that commercial scale but on a smaller scale. Among the things that he also listed as part of recommendation, which I also support him, is the establishment of an Agricultural Finance Support Fund. I believe this will also go a long way to help many farmers and especially also help reduce their burden and also serve as an incentive for many banks who also want to support and partner them in this regard.

Mr Speaker, in the area of the Public-Private Partnership (PPP), I believe that is also one area that we can also look at in supporting many of our farmers who are in dire need of the financial support. While at this, we can also not gloss over and pretend that the role of Government as a major player in the agricultural sector can be washed away. It is a tragedy for a small-scale farmer to sweat, put in all the effort, and at the end of the day, the Government will turn its back on the farmer. Mr Speaker, I am bringing this issue as a matter of urgent concern that we have many of our farmers today, who do not even find it worthy to even go into farming in the next planting season. They have their maize. After harvesting it, issues of even storage become a problem. The issue of cocoa is still fresh on our minds. Many of our farmers we are talking about are not even cultivating on a 100-acre scale, 200 acres, some 20, 10, or 5 acres. And if they can also have this major crop and

still Government will not even buy from them or pay them, then it becomes a disincentive for some of these farmers to go into farming. While we have cocoa issues to deal with, you also have that of rice. We have many of our small-scale farmers and many of our farmers in the rural communities who are keeping the nation going. Seventy per cent of what we eat is coming from the agricultural sector. What is the role of Government in helping these farmers when they cultivate and go through all the hustle in putting food on our table?

So, it is important that as we also try to establish an agricultural farm, Government must also play its critical role and not turn its back on these farmers. We talk about yam, rice, maize and cocoa. So, there is something serious happening at the agricultural sector that I believe we also have to take a critical look at. Yes, we can have PPP or a Fund being set up, but the critical role of the Government in ensuring that they provide these incentives for these farmers for them to also continue to hold us down as a nation. It cannot be rhetoric all the time, Mr Speaker. It cannot also be lamentations all the time. Once we have a problem, we must fix it.

I support the maker of this Statement in this regard and I believe that other Members of Parliament will also contribute effectively to this Statement.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, my Brother. Yes, Prof Hamza Adam?

Prof Hamza Adam (NDC — Kumbungu): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to this very important subject under discussion and to thank the maker of this Statement for touching a very important and sensitive matter, which has to do with financing for smallholder farmers. Mr Speaker, as the maker had it spot on, the chunk of the food we get from this country comes from the smallholder farmer. The smallholder farmer plays a critical role in providing food for the people of this country. Unfortunately, they go through a lot of difficulties. They have numerous challenges and then financing is one of the critical challenges that the smallholder farmer faces. So, there is a need to find a way of addressing this critical matter.

Financing smallholder farmer has been a perennial problem. It has been long outstanding. There have been a lot of interventions to support smallholder farmer to be able to enhance farming. Unfortunately, a lot of these interventions have not been successful and one of the critical challenges is the fact that the high interest rates that normally come with the loans makes it very difficult for the smallholder farmer to be able to access the funding.

Mr Speaker. I worked closely on a Millenium Development Authority (MiDA) project, which was supposed to commercialise smallholder farmers. But one of the difficulties that the project faced had to do with financing. They took the farmers through the starter packs, which was very successful and very promising. But when it got to the

time of providing financing or loans for the farmers, it was a big problem. Because we noticed that a lot of the farmers were running away because of the high interest rate.

3:37 p.m.

There is a need to look at this particular issue and see how we are going to make financing accessible and affordable for the smallholder farmer.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, it is important to ensure that we are able to address the following challenges so that the smallholder farmer is able to stay in business and continue to feed us as a country. One of the challenges in commercialising a smallholder farmer is the fact that they have fragmented lands, which makes it difficult for them to commercialise. So, there is a need for the Ministry of Food and Agriculture to see how they can put them into a co-operative so that they can have their land together and do commercial farming.

The other important thing is the food glut. As we stand now, the country is battling with a food glut because we do not determine prices for our produce, which is very important. So, we must find a way as a country to see how we can fix prices for food produce, because the farmers cannot predict how much they will sell their produce. It is very challenging. They invest so much, and when they harvest, they are not able to sell or get realistic prices for their produce.

The other important thing we have to do is to consider the rural industrialisation. We should find industries that are suitable for a particular place and grow them so that the farm produce can be transformed into a more marketable product for them. So, for example, if one comes to the Northern Region, we have a potential for producing—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Prof Hamza. Your time is up.

Nana Osei-Adjei (NPP — New Juaben North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this brilliant Statement made by our Colleague from Kpando, Sebastian Deh.

Mr Speaker, this Statement exposes a painful truth about our smallholder farmers and what they go through. For decades, as a country, we have paid lip service to the support of our smallholder farmers, especially in financing. Our sisters, like Kenya, have been able to move on from not financing smallholder farmers to an era where smallholder farmers can access facilities within days, not weeks, but days. They have been able to build a proper digital platform for the smallholder farmers.

Mr Speaker, if you may bear with me, the previous Government started a digital project which would have been very solid for our smallholder farmers. But I know that when we come back, we

will be able to do that. Banks in this country should be able to develop tailor-made products that will help our smallholder farmers. I was intrigued to read from his Statement that, with your kind permission, I may read: “Mr Speaker, we cannot overlook the critical role of women and youth in agriculture. Women constitute the majority of our smallholder farmers”.

Mr Speaker, I am being mindful of Order 93(5). If women constitute the majority of our smallholder farmers, I would advise that this Statement should be taken with keen interest in the sense that their own Government told all of us that they were going to establish the Women’s Development Bank within six months. If this bank had been established, our women would have access to facilities that would help our smallholder farmers.

So, I advise the maker of the Statement to ensure that it reaches the doorsteps of the Flagstaff House.

Mr Speaker, our Deputy Minister for Finance also came here and told us that there are banks that are offering facilities at a rate of 10 to 11 per cent per annum. Meaning there are banks in this country that can help our smallholder farmers. So, I also entreat the maker of the Statement to also make it available to our Deputy Minister for Finance so that our women will be able to see the light of day.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: My Brother, are you up on your feet? All right, let us hear you.

Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (NDC — Pru East): Mr Speaker, thank you.

I want to seize this opportunity to thank the maker of the Statement and also bring to the fore some of these things that are plaguing our farmers. Especially when he mentioned Opportunity International Savings and Loans Ltd. For the past 20 years, they have been committed to the farmers. And it is across wherever their branches can be found.

Unfortunately, agriculture happens to be the only way that the majority of Ghanaians can be employed. Yet, successive governments come and fail to address this particular challenge. This has actually affected how our young farmers and women appreciate farming in our country. Most of our women are persistent farmers. They do not farm large scale, yet it is very difficult for them to access credit. What most of this micro scheme does is to train whoever is coming for funding from them. So, they help in imparting a skill, open an account, and then they cultivate into them the habit of saving. There is a direct link with this type of funding and financial inclusion. Financial inclusion has an impact on economic development.

Mr Speaker, when you look at the maker of the Statement, what has been

put before us, it is clear that there are certain pertinent produce like pepper, maize, vegetables, and other things that most of our women are into. These are things that we can easily support our women to go into. Without necessarily having to fall on importation or having to go to our neighbouring countries to bring them. I do not want to recall this unfortunate incident where our people from Ghana went to the neighbouring country to bring tomatoes, and the unfortunate happened. But this is the crux of the matter; when we do not pay attention to funding and also supporting these young women in agriculture, these are some of the emergencies that come our way.

We want to state that as a country, if we indeed want to reduce the unemployment rate, this is the way to go. Because when we have a woman in farming, it is not just about the woman, but whatever she gets out of farming comes to affect a whole family. And that is the way our mothers have supported us till this time.

3:47 p.m.

Anyone who comes from any agricultural environment will see that women play a critical role in having to raise their families up with the menial sales they get from their farm produce. So, helping them access credit is just not about the bank trying to make gains off them, but it is rather a way of bringing potential people to have a sustainable lifestyle.

It is time for our rural banks and microcredit facilities to also turn their attention to some of our communities and support them. Sometimes, most of them even charge unrealistic interest rates. So, in the end, when they support the farmer, at the end of the day, he or she is unable to pay and then it becomes a delinquent and non-performing loan.

We would want to state that in as much as we are looking at supporting farmers, we should also look at practical ways of giving credit to our women and financing our people, so that they can pay back. When it comes to my Constituency which is Pru East, there are rural banks that support pepper farmers. It is very good because they look at the climate condition and then they support them. We should also factor the climate conditions that our farmers go through. Let us begin to support them with irrigational facilities, so that even within the whole year, we can have this farming going on.

Mr Speaker, we thank the maker of this Statement and I believe this Statement would not end up on our shelves as always, but we would put it into action. So that the ordinary Ghanian is supported.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the two contributors have exhausted their time. Leadership?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, thank you for this opportunity. I would want to take this opportunity to thank the maker of the Statement, who is the Member of Parliament for Kpando.

Mr Speaker, a cursory look at what is happening in respect of smallholder farms, one would advert to, first of all, the problems they are confronted with. Largely, it has to do with issues of land litigation. When they are dealing with about five-acre land, somebody comes and says that he is the owner of the land and then they end up having all manner of litigations.

Mr Speaker, beyond the litigation is also the issue of access to financing. When they get the financing, as difficult as that may be, they are also expected to pay a lot of interest on those funds.

Mr Speaker, the other aspect is also the issue of drought. There are a lot of environmental issues and they end up having issues of drought when farming.

Mr Speaker, 90 to 95 per cent of farming activities are within these remits. Therefore, one would expect that farms in Ghana, which are about 90 to 95 per cent are small holder farms. They produce majority of the food crops that we keep talking about such as maize, cocoa, cassava, yam, rice, cocoa and plantain.

Mr Speaker, in recent times, all these staple foods I have mentioned, especially rice, yam and maize, these farmers are having a problem to even transport them. Apart from transportation, they are not getting people to buy them. The market is virtually non-existent. So, this is the right time for the maker of the Statement to have brought this it to the fore, for Government to take a critical look as to how they would support these smallholder farmers.

Mr Speaker, most cocoa farmers have virtually abandoned their farms. They are more excited about giving out their farms for mining activities and not just the normal mining activities, but rather *galamsey*. When you have a farmer who expected the Government of the day to have given him or her GHC6,000 per a bag, as promised, then, that farmer goes back home and now gets GHC2,500—One can understand what is happening. A lot of them are suffering from high blood pressure and stroke.

They are giving them interests that they are unable to pay. The roads are not accessible for them to be able to transport their commodities or their products into the markets where they can be purchased. There is no money for people to even sell their rice, cocoyam and yams. That was the reason why my respected Leader even had to come and show to this House that this is yam, cocoa, maize and rice. We are not getting money to buy them.

Mr Speaker, there is food drought and the worst part is that they always have the President promising them that he would sink boreholes for them. How do you sink boreholes for the 90 to 95 per cent of farmers who are in Ghana? Sink boreholes in these modern times?

Mr Speaker, we need to pay critical attention to all these matters and let us have a solid vision for our smallholder farmers. Let us move from giving money to a Ministry that they should give GHC71 million to pay social media experts, when they can give this money to smallholder farmers. They should stop getting on private jets to go and deal with issues elsewhere when we need to support smallholder farmers.

Mr Speaker, I would pray that this Statement be remitted to the Presidency, for them to know what is happening to smallholder farmers. So that they can take critical look at it and solve the problems the Ghanaian people are facing.

I thank you very much for this opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Yes, Majority Leadership?

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, let me commend the Member for Kpando for such an important Statement. If one travels from Dabala all the way to Anloga in the Volta Region and from

Anloga all the way to Keta, you have nearly every household with a farm dotted along the lagoon front. If you travel from Apam all the way to Cape Coast, you have families that have farms dotted along the highway. If you travel from Mpraeso through Asaka to Tafo then, to Enchi in the Kwahu area, you have families that have farms dotted along the highway. As for the entire Afram Plains region, that is the breadbasket of the nation.

Mr Speaker, when you are on a flight and you are about to land at the Tamale Airport, the entire Tamale metropolis is surrounded by farmlands. There is practically farming going on everywhere. So, the focus of the Statement is for us as a people to fashion a deliberate policy to be able to support the small farm holders. But how do we do it?

We have introduced policies like youth in agriculture. But how do we mobilise the youth to participate in agriculture for production, feeding, and industry? In addition to the proposals contained in the Statement, I believe that as a people, we should be able to have block farming. It simply means that we should farm in lots. What does it mean? For instance, in South Dayi, we should be able to acquire 100 acres stretch of land and subdivide that into about 10 acres each, into subplots and reduce those 10 acres into different crops, if that is the case and assign, say, two tractors to this block farm in South Dayi. This would allow the youth to acquire these 10-acre subplots and reduce them into

whatever crops that they want to engage in.

Mr Speaker, by this, if all the 261 districts can have a minimum of 100 acres of farmland turned into a block farm, that will amount to having in excess of 2,610 acres of land reduced into block farming.

3:57 p.m.

What that also means is that data collection becomes easy. In fact, the farmers can access credit electronically, as is done in Rwanda, Tanzania and Kenya. We do not need to send any officer to the farm to go and collect data, because the financial institutions can simply, with the use of Google Maps, zoom in and look at the size of the farm, which are all calculable with the use of Information Technology. We can determine which crop is under cultivation and the size of the farm.

Mr Speaker, the maker of the Statement also spoke about climate-sensitive farming methods. In fact, a couple of years ago, the Akufo Addo government introduced greenhouse farming and I know that equipment was distributed to a lot of farmers. Now, we cannot find them. We have imported a lot of tractors into this country for purposes of distribution to farmers. We cannot find the tractors. So, we need to be very deliberate about this.

Mr Speaker, if I may have your buy-in, I think we should refer the Statement to the Committee on Food and

Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs for them to consider and bring a report and see whether we can engage the ministry to pilot block farming in a couple of districts, to see how it goes.

Mr Speaker, with these words, we want to thank the Member for the Statement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Did I see the Chairperson of the Committee on Food and Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs here? I think I saw him.

Referred to the Committee on Food Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs.

Mr Dafeamekpor: He has travelled.

Mr Speaker, there is a prayer by Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama. He has to travel shortly, so I pray that we bring up his Statement so that he can make it quickly. Let us vary the order of the Statements so that he can take it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to item (h), Statement by Hon Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama, Member for Walewale.

Hon Member, you may take your Statement now.

Decline of Youth Financing from the District Assemblies Common Fund to the NYA and YEA

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Mr Speaker, I want to thank Leadership and your good self for this honour and to thank my

Colleagues, more especially Hon Eric Edem Agbana and Hon Emmanuel Tobbin, for yielding and ceding to me to make this Statement.

Mr Speaker, I rise to make this Statement on the decline of youth financing from the District Assemblies Common Fund to the National Youth Authority (NYA) and the Youth Employment Agency (YEA). The development of youth is the foundation of every nation that aims to strengthen its overall progress. This is both recognised in the National Youth Policy (2022-2032) and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). The Volunteer National Report (VNR) of 2035 specifically emphasised SDG target 8.5, thus achieving full and productive employment and decent work for all, including young people and persons with disabilities and SDG target 8.6, substantially reducing the proportion of youth not in employment, education, and or training. However, these targets are being undermined by inadequate and inconsistent financing for youth programmes.

Mr Speaker, the youth continue to face significant barriers such as limited entrepreneurial support, funding, vocational and technical skills training, leaving them either unemployed or in vulnerable employment. For example, according to the 2022-2023 Annual Household Income Expenditure Survey, seven in every 10 persons, that is about 1.3 million unemployed persons in the

third quarter of 2023, were aged 15 to 35. Of those who were even said to be employed, estimated to be around 3.1 million youth, were said to be in vulnerable employment. The survey also revealed that 1.2 million youth are excluded from the use of ICT devices and another 2.3 million, which is about 19.7 per cent, did not use the internet.

Mr Speaker, in response to the need for a more structured and sustainable framework, this House passed the Youth Employment Agency Act, 2015 (Act 887), and the National Youth Authority Act, 2016 (Act 939). The goal of these Acts was to empower these institutions to oversee the development, coordination, supervision and facilitation of youth employment. Importantly, both Acts made explicit provision to ensure sustainable financing of these agencies. Specifically, Section 17 (b) of Act 939 and Section 23 (c) of Act 887 mandates that 5 per cent of the District Assemblies Common Fund be allocated to the National Youth Authority and 10 per cent to the YEA annually, subject to the formula approved by Parliament under Article 252 of the Constitution.

Mr Speaker, this was to generate predictable and adequate funding to enable these institutions to perform their mandate effectively. The current Government has outlined a roadmap to operationalise its youth development and employment strategy, as outlined in the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Manifesto for 2024, primarily through

the establishment of its new Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment. This is also to build on key interventions in previous governments through youth entrepreneurship and skill development, with the National Apprenticeship Programme (NAP) and the *Adwumawura* Initiative. These youth-based initiatives are driven by institutions such as the NYA and the National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme, (NEIP). According to the NYA, an amount of GH¢ 400 million has been received through the District Assemblies Common Fund since 2017. Of this amount, 79 per cent has been spent on youth-related infrastructure development across the country, including youth resource centres, youth leadership skills training institutes, astro-turf facilities, regional and district directorates and national office complexes.

Mr Speaker, about 17 per cent has been spent on programmes and operations, while the remaining 4 per cent was spent on goods and services and general administration over the past nine years. Demonstrably, the NYA has effectively utilised the resources to empower the youth and create an enabling environment for effective and meaningful youth engagement in the country. Regrettably, the trend in recent years paints a disturbing picture. It is interesting to note that between 2017 and 2019, compliance with the statutory funding requirement was largely achieved. However, from 2020, there has

been a consistent decline. Available data indicates that between 2020 and 2024, the average annual release from the District Assemblies Common Fund to the NYA stood at only 2.8 per cent while the YEA received about 5.8 per cent, which is far below their statutory allocation of 5 per cent and 10 per cent, respectively. Even more concerning is that in the first quarter of 2025, both agencies have received just 0.6 per cent of their expected allocation.

Mr Speaker, reports from the Youth Empowerment for Life in Ghana (YEFL-Ghana), a youth-focused civil organisation based in the northern region, through its “Follow the Money” campaign between 2017 and 2025 support this worrying revelation of inconsistency in the District Assemblies Common Fund’s disbursement to the NYA and the YEA. This downward trajectory is not merely a statistical issue, it has real implications for the lives of the millions of young Ghanaians who depend on this institution for training, employment and empowerment opportunities. The decline undermines the very essence of our collective vision for inclusive and sustainable development. It also weakens the institutional capacity of NYA and YEA to deliver on their respective mandates.

Mr Speaker, the youth of Ghana remain our most valuable national asset. If properly supported, we can become the engine of innovation, productivity and leadership that will prepare Ghana

toward middle-income prosperity and beyond.

4:07 p.m.

However, to unlock this potential, the Government must prioritise and protect youth financing, especially through consistent and timely disbursement of national district assembly common fund allocations as prescribed by law.

Mr Speaker, this Government came to office with a vision of resetting the nation and restoring economic stability. In that spirit, I appeal earnestly to the Minister for Finance and the District Assemblies Common Fund Secretariat to take immediate steps to ensure statutory funds due to the National Youth Authority (NYA) and the Youth Employment Agency (YEA) are released fully and promptly. Delays and shortfalls in the releases only serve to erode public confidence in our youth policies and derail the progress we collectively seek.

Mr Speaker, given this worrying decline and non-compliance of this statutory allocation in the past years, I will urge the responsible institution, that is the District Assemblies Common Fund, the YEA, the NYA, the Minister for Youth Development and Employment, to engage with the Parliamentary Select Committee on Youth and Sports to take a second look at the decline in compliance issue and to immediately take steps to find a redress to it. Such

engagement should aim to build the cause of non-compliance and propose remedial measures, including ensuring strict adherence to the 2026 National Budget. Unfortunately, this has elapsed, but going into the future in 2026—

In conclusion, I firmly believe that any investment that improves the well-being and productivity of our youth is an investment in the future. It is therefore imperative that we restore full compliance with the provisions of Act 887 and Act 939 to safeguard the sustainability of our youth development architecture.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. The same rules apply to both Sides; nobody is speaking for more than five minutes.

Yes, Hon Dr Sosu, Member for Madina?

Dr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu (NDC — Madina): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Maker of the Statement for such a well-researched Statement—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The two from each Side include Leadership.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Yes, Mr Speaker, we have resolved among

ourselves that we will take one on each Side. So that Leadership will conclude.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So that is what I am saying that it includes Leadership.

Mr Richard Acheampong: All right. That is fine.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Sosu, let us hear you.

Dr Sosu: Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Maker of the Statement for such a well-researched Statement, particularly the one bordering on the young people of our country.

Mr Speaker, the Statement is so critical because we know of the issues of youth unemployment, and we know the core mandate of the YEA and the NYA. Indeed, if we can change our narrative as a people, we must begin to prepare young people to become entrepreneurs and it is the YEA and the NYA that have the mandate or the core mandate to prepare our young people to become entrepreneurial.

Mr Speaker, one of the reasons there is so much *brouhaha* in town today is the fact that we have a number of young people who are looking for government jobs that are not available. The reality is that Adam Smith's theory of scarcity still prevails. The resources available to us as a nation cannot satisfy all the needs we have as a people. There is no way the spaces available can support the total

number of young people looking for jobs, and the only way as a people we can begin to make progress is when we prepare these young people to invest in themselves, technical, vocational and some form of entrepreneurship and that is the core mandate of the YEA, and that is why I support the Maker of the Statement that we must, as part of the Reset Agenda, reset the funding to these agencies.

I can assure the Maker of the Statement that His Excellency John Dramani Mahama is a man of integrity and definitely will take this call in good faith, and we can see some serious funding to the YEA so that it can carry out its core mandate to secure the future of our young people in Ghana.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to support the Statement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Hon Asafo-Adjei.

Mr Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh (NPP — Bosome Freho): Mr Speaker, I would like to also commend my good Brother and Colleague from Walewale, Hon Dr Kabiru Mahama.

Mr Speaker, this is an important Statement, and for me, the figures and the details he has put across are mind-boggling. The number of unemployed youth we have, seven out of ten persons

we meet are unemployed, and the effort that successive governments have tried to make, particularly in financing or finding a lasting solution to this youth unemployment problem.

Mr Speaker, my point or major focus of the contribution will be about the efforts or activities of successive governments that largely have an intention of creating jobs, but end up not creating the jobs we are looking for.

Mr Speaker, not quite long ago, the current President, who was President from 2012 to 2016, came out with a lot of initiatives with the intention of creating jobs for the youth. He came out with youth in bead making, youth in bicycle riding, youth in film making and youth in pothole patching. These are programmes that we commit a lot of money into and at the end of the day end up in sham, including Muslims in piggery and all that. This was the result of how Ghanaians ended up in lawsuits about corruption.

Mr Speaker, so my point is clear. Today, my good Brother is talking about YEA. In the Message on the State of the Nation, President John Dramani Mahama mentioned that 89,000 youth have been engaged in various modules.

Mr Speaker, as at the time he was giving the Message on the State of the Nation, the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the YEA had not even been in office. In 2016, when the President again

came here to make a Statement before us, he again mentioned that he had instructed that the YEA programme be reviewed to avoid duplication.

Mr Speaker, my point is clear that we cannot overly as a country to implement programmes, activities, and initiatives that will end up coming back to the same cycle without creating lasting and permanent jobs for our youth.

Mr Speaker, it is as if our youth are beginning to be the point at which we tell them anything, and then they fall for us, for us to win elections. Not long ago, the President of this country went to Winneba, and then behind him was a big wall clock. Telling everybody that he is going to create a one-three-three job, that, for example, Ama will go to work in the morning and close in the afternoon. Kofi will go in the afternoon, for an eight-hour shift, and close. Then, Kwame takes over and comes the next day, one-three-three, to curb the issue of unemployment in this country. Now we are here, 2025 is gone. In 2026, the best they have done about the one-three-three initiative is to create an Authority, which in itself closes at 4:00 p.m.

Mr Speaker, this is how we have, over the years, used our youth as a *chaskele* ball. We play with them, we toy with their emotions, we ride on them, we gain popularity, win elections and do not do anything about them.

Mr Speaker, the financing of the youth must be something that we should be interested in.

Mr Speaker, it is not about rhetoric. It should be about commitment to ensuring that the teeming members of our society who are young and unemployed must be given some work and a job to do.

4:17 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we now have H. E. John Mahama again as a president. I am only cautioning, that the youth in pot-hole patching, the youth in beads making, the youth in bicycle riding, the Muslims in piggery should not be repeated. We are seeing some clear signs with the Adwumawura Programme. Mr Speaker, we are only hearing that 2,000 of them have been trained. Even them, they have not been able to equip them or tool them to go and work.

Mr Speaker, the conclusion—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me come to Leadership. Let your Leader address it. The Minority Leadership has yielded, I presume.

Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP — Akuapem North): Mr Speaker, let me commend the maker of the Statement for bringing such an important matter to the attention of the House. Mr Speaker, I think what is happening in the country is pretending to be creating jobs for the young people, when in actual sense, it is like an Instagram kind of situation where we are made to believe something is being done but not being done. Again, if we look at the allocation from the

District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF) to that of the National Youth Authority (NYA) and that of the Youth Employment Agency (YEA), it is worrying. Already, they are struggling to release the 5 per cent and the 10 per cent. Now, we have these institutions also struggling to even cope with the burden that they come face-to-face with all the time.

Mr Speaker, even the structural arrangement of even the YEA is problematic. A situation where we have young people being recruited and employed for two years. After two years, they are made to exit the programme and we recruit another young group of people to be employed for two years. So, clearly, it is a recycle of unemployment situation that we have in our country. Much scarier, Mr Speaker, is the recent Ghana Statistical Service report where in Greater Accra alone, one out of two young people that you meet remain unemployed. So, Mr Speaker, that is very scary. If in the midst of all this, we have Government not having a coordinated strategy to employ young people, it gives us cause to worry.

Again, let me buttress the point of my Colleague that this “settings” arrangement of one-three-three people working around the 24-hour clock, it is clear that it is not going to work. For a year now, what they have established is a secretariat. The Secretariat themselves are telling us they aim to recruit people.

At a point in time, I do not know why my senior Vandal Colleague was upset when my Colleague mentioned the

Muslims in piggery. Here in this Chamber, the President of the Republic said he was showcasing people that they had employed and said Amina had been given some support to go into piggery. Amina was a practising and is still a practising Muslim. So, when they say Muslims in piggery, they created it.

Mr Speaker, subsequent to that, we also have a situation where Mr President comes to us in this Chamber and tells us that as part of the Big Push and in the same Budget Statement of the President of the Republic, they are telling us they are going to create about 800,000 jobs through the Big Push. A greater percentage of these 800,000 jobs is “by-day” work. People going to carry water, fetch water, carry concrete and all. After six or seven months, they are back to square one. That is not the kind of jobs that President Mahama and the NDC promised us when they were campaigning in 2024. We believe that the lip service period is over. The honeymoon now, it is clear, is over. Eyes clear. Let us get to the realities on the ground. We are still looking forward to—

Recently, Mr Speaker, my very good Friend and Brother, Felix Ofori Kwakye said last year they were going to even establish 600 CHPS compounds. That could have employed many young people. A year down the line, you ask him and he tells you it is not his policy, it is that of Government policy. Mr Speaker, the situation we have is a very

serious matter and we expect our Colleagues on the other Side to attach seriousness to the issues of unemployment.

Now the issue of security recruitment. Over 500,000 young people were convinced, let me put it that way, that they were going to get jobs, paid GH¢200—And they knew that they were going to only recruit 5,000 people. A hundred million cedis, nicely accrued, I will not say pocketed, but to the disadvantage of the young people. We want to see much more seriousness from our Colleagues.

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by my good Friend, Hon Kabiru. Mr Speaker, the maker of the Statement is a Muslim, yet he sat down quietly for another Asafo-Adjei Ayeh to tell all of us that there was a programme called Muslim in piggery, and he was laughing.

Mr Speaker, our Brothers and Sisters are in their fasting season, Ramadan. He is here making mockery of them. We never had any programme called Muslim in piggery, so Mr Speaker, that statement should be expunged from the records. Unless he can prove to us that we implemented a programme called

Muslim in piggery. If somebody mentions Amina, does it mean that every Amina is a Muslim? How can he conclude that? I was in this House when that Statement was made. So if you mention Amina or Siaka, it does not mean that person is a Muslim.

Mr Speaker, the Statement is revealing certain things to us. I thank Hon Kabiru for telling us this story. He used to work at the office of the former Vice President. He telling us that between 2020 and 2024, instead of DACF ceding 5 per cent to NYA, they only gave them 2.8 per cent under their watch. Instead of giving YEA 10 per cent, they gave them 5.8 per cent. Meanwhile, between 2017 and 2019, they received GH¢400 million. What did they use that money for? He is reporting to us that they used 17 per cent for programmes and operations, 4 per cent for goods and services and administration expenditures, and 79 per cent spent on youth-related infrastructure development. They refused to report this to us then. Today, they are telling us that there was a wastage. The money meant for youth development was used for other purposes.

We thank you for telling us what you did with the GH¢400 million. That is why we put in Adwumawura programme, Nkoko Nketenkete programme, youth apprenticeship programme. The Statement is telling us that about 1.2 million youth are excluded from the use of ICT. So, the one Million

Coders Programme is going to fix that challenge. He is also telling us that 2.3 million people did not even use internet at all. We need to develop the youth because they are the future of this nation. So, it is good he brought out all this information, though he failed to address it during their regime. But governance is a continuum.

This Government is taking steps to make sure that we put the youth at a proper place so that they can get meaningful work to do. We are just 14 months in office. So, what they could not fix, this administration is going to fix so that the youth will have hope. When we are not there, they are going to take over from us. So, we thank him very much for bringing up this issue because the people having this challenge are between 15 and 35 years. We need to deal with it. The Government is not complaining. The Government is taking steps to fix what they could not fix. So

Mr Speaker, we thank him for bringing up the problem that they created. But the youth are the youth of this nation.

4:27 p.m.

We will make sure the right thing is done so that the youth will get a better future to help us develop this nation. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will turn to the Statement numbered (f).

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with your leave, I would want to humbly apply for a variation of the proceedings to enable us to go to page 37 of today's *Order Paper* and deal with item numbered 57.

Mr Speaker, the item numbered 57 is a Private Member's Motion anchored on Article 103 of the 1992 Constitution and Orders 204, 212, 213, 262 and 263 of the Standing Orders of Parliament.
[*Interruption*]

Mr Dafeamekpor: Is he moving it?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, I am not moving it. I am asking for leave and I need to explain.

To establish an Ad Hoc committee to investigate the Gold-for-Reserves Scheme, including its design, implementation, governance, financial performance, environmental and public health implications, and any related matters.

Mr Speaker, this Motion has the following applicants: Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo, Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib, Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah and Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah. The Motion was admitted by the Rt Hon Speaker as far back as 29th December, 2025. In the first Business Committee meeting, same was considered to be moved the very first week upon resumption. Upon my count, this is the sixth week since we

resumed. We have had assurances upon assurances to take this Motion.

Last two weeks, we were promised that we were going to take it, but it did not happen. Again, this week, we pressed and were assured by our Friends on the opposite Side that the Motion will be taken today. Our Colleagues who are the applicants of this Motion are ready. This is parliamentary Business. I think that the more Motions delay on the *Order Paper*, the higher the likelihood of a certain impression being created in the minds of the public as if in Parliament we cannot agree to proceed on something and dispense with same.

Mr Speaker, this is a matter that you will rule. *[Interruption]* No, I am not moving the Motion please. Hon Etse Dafeamekpor should not do this. His Leader is here, so he should relax. This is Leader to Leader. He is not the acting-Leader. Let me finish.

Mr Speaker, the issue here is let us move our Motion, debate it, and then the ruling is made. When the ruling is made—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: He is not moving the Motion now.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I must give you good reasons to know why this application is not being made in bad faith. I should not make a lame application. The grounds of my

plaint must be well anchored and that is exactly what I am doing. I am saying that we should be allowed to proceed, debate, and then you make a ruling on it. Once you make a ruling on it, we know that we are done with it.

But if week after week the Motion is in there—and there is even a second Motion that has to do with the mass dismissal. When I check the date, it is even passed a year. That Motion was dated 5th March, 2025. Every week it appears on the *Order Paper*, and that is also here. It has been a year since the Motion was moved, seconded and debate started. We cannot continue since any time we raise it we are told that, we should wait for then next week and it is passed a year. Meanwhile, people have been dismissed. They expect Parliament to speak.

So, Mr Speaker, we pray that the Majority should keep to their word. We all agreed that today we will take this Motion, grant this leave for the applicants to move their Motion, let them come with their counter-issues, let us debate it, and, Mr Speaker, should rule whether or not there should be a referral to a Committee to escalate the matter. I so submit, most humbly.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think the Minority Leader has severally raised the issue of Motions that he has proposed and which have been admitted by the Rt Hon Speaker. But generally, the indication we get from the

Rt Hon Speaker is that he would like to preside over those Motions.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, come again. I did not get that.

Mr Ayariga: I am saying that he has raised the issue of his Motions and the Rt Hon Speaker has given indication that he wants to be in the Chair when those Motions are being taken. The Hon Minority Leader actually came two days ago and again raised the issue and even proposed that the two of us should go to the Rt Hon Speaker's office and try and convince him to come and preside so that we will take the Motions. It is just that we were not able to go and see the Speaker.

So, it is not the case that anybody is afraid of the Motion being taken. It is just the availability of the Rt Hon Speaker himself to preside over those Motions or to give an indication that his deputies should go ahead and take the Motions. I do not see how the Motions he is talking about are of real value because the issue in one of them is about the mass dismissal. This was extensively debated in the House and the Speaker ruled on it based on our own Standing Orders which says that when a matter is in court, we cannot discuss it.

Now he is saying that he is appealing against the decision of the Rt Hon Speaker on that matter. I do not see any new arguments that he is going to proffer. It is going to be the same thing.

The case is still in court. The matter has not been withdrawn.

The second issue that he wants to raise, is about Ghana Gold Board losses. We are ready for him because we have reports that also show that Ghana Gold Board is doing so well and every Ghanaian can feel how well Gold Board is doing. So, it is not something we are afraid of. We are ready to discuss and debate it. So, there is no issue of anybody being afraid to discuss anything because there is nothing that he going to say that he has not said on radio for Ghanaians to hear. There is nothing that he is going to say in this Chamber that he has not said at a press conference. There is nothing earth-shattering about any new thing that he is going to say.

But with all that, we have continued to exist with a stable cedi, a weakened dollar, and inflation that continues to go down. So, there is nothing new that he is going to say. There is nothing we are afraid of. But as I keep emphasising, he and I have got the indication from the Rt Hon Speaker on how he wants the matter treated.

So, all I can say is that let the Deputy Speakers confer with the Rt Hon Speaker and let them decide when they want the Motions taken. He is not the only one who has Motions advertised. There are so many Motions that have been advertised. Some are even in my name. But I am not pushing because I see that the signals from the Rt Hon Speaker is

that he does not want those ones taken now. So, I plead with him that it is not from the Majority Side. Because, the Motions, I can assure the Hon Minority Leader that like Idi Amin said, he will fight the British Empire with one hand tied behind him. So, he can move his Motions. I will just unleash Hon Felix Kwakye Ofosu on him and the matter would be resolved in terms of the quality of the debate.

4:37 p.m.

We are not afraid. By the time I add Hon Alhassan Suhuyini, the case will be clearly determined. If I add Hon Grace Ayensu-Danquah for gender balance, then the matter will be finished. So, we are not afraid. So, I plead with him, let us get the Rt Hon Speaker to give indications to his Deputies and direct them on how to treat the Motions that they have filed.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have listened carefully and attentively to the Majority Leader, who responded to my application for leave to take the Motion numbered 57. Mr Speaker, in his response to me, he talked about inflation, the dollar-cedi—What he failed to discuss was a huge unemployment situation, the worsening *galamsey* situation, and the 506,000 who have applied for 5,000 jobs and they are still losing money. These are matters that he admits.

Mr Speaker, on the issue of indication from the Rt Hon Speaker, he is right, and it is fair. Indeed, he and I agreed that we should go and see the Rt

Hon Speaker, but that is in respect of Motions 53 and 54. Those were Motions that he had indicated, and I did the count; it has been over a year. Currently, the Motion that I am talking about is Motion 57. That is not part of the two Motions that the Rt Hon Speaker said he wants to take. As for these two Motions, when we were at Conclave, the understanding with the Rt Hon Speaker was that this one, we can have it today, Thursday, and that was a week ago. So, I agree with him that we had an understanding to see the Rt Hon Speaker on Motions 53 and 54. That is true. I will not deny that fact, but I am not pushing for those two Motions to be moved. At least, I want to exhaust that gentleman's agreement with him that we should see the Rt Hon Speaker. I was expressing a view that since he will rule, at least, he will rule based on record. So, if he is not available, he should at least allow any of the Deputies to preside for us to conclude the debate, then he can refer to the record and then do his ruling. When we meet him, I will put forth that argument. But for the time being, I would not press what we have agreed to do.

What I am talking about is Motion 57, which has to do with the Gold Board and the Bank of Ghana situation. Mr Speaker, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) Report to the country is that there were GH¢7 billion losses as of 31st December, 2025, and we need to debate this matter. Debate on the radio is not debate in public records. Let us deal with this, let there be a ruling, then we know that the matter has been dealt with.

As for the Motion I am making an application for, it is not one of the Motions that the Rt Hon Speaker has indicated that he wants to preside, in all fairness. Majority Leader, I have been fair with the facts. I do not want us to say this and that. I have Hon Asafo-Adjei Ayeh over there. I will not even unleash second timers; I am going to unleash the first timers to deal with his team. I would not let second timers—Hon John Darko is there. Mr Speaker, you know we have the strikers. Lawyer Mmieh is there. The first timers will deal with his team, so I do not have a problem. He can call his Ministers to come. I know that he wants to prepare and bring all the Ministers to populate this Chamber. We fear nothing. Mr Speaker, we do not fear his numbers. We are mighty in our few numbers.

So, Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader should not entertain any worries at all. We have a full, well-prepared Backbench to deal with his Seniors. They are so solid. They are determined; we have prepared them, and we know we will make a compelling argument for the Rt Hon Speaker to make a referral. Mr Speaker, I end my case.

Mr Ayariga: Well, Mr Speaker, as indicated, this is not a matter that we should take today. As for the IMF, I do not know if there are any rules in this House that say that whatever the IMF says is sacrosanct. Because we know that the practice has always been that the Central Bank is audited, and there is an annual audit report that comes to Parliament. It is only when that audit report gets to this House, and there is any

confirmation of what is being alleged, that we can also begin to look into it.

Mr Speaker, we know that under our 1992 Constitution, the Bank has a reporting obligation to Parliament. We know that. We could invite them and ask them Questions. Indeed, we can ask the Governor Questions, and he will be compelled to come to this Chamber and answer those Questions. Why do they choose a Motion so that they can come and say anything that can undermine the Central Bank of the country? Why did they choose the option of a Motion? And to say that we should form an Ad hoc Committee? To look into what?

Mr Speaker, clearly, this is not a matter that this House should spend its time on. But he brought the Motion, the Speaker has admitted the Motion, and it has been advertised. Wait until the Rt Hon Speaker gives an indication that he wants the Motion taken. Our rules are very clear. Order 191 states:

“(1) The House shall allot two hours each Friday and any other day for the consideration of Private Member’s Bill and Private Member’s Motion.

(2) Despite rule (1), the Speaker may extend the period for the consideration of Private Member’s Bill or Private Member’s Motion, having regard to the state of business in the House.”

We have not really been doing this, and it is important for us to encourage a culture of private Motions and then have

our two hours dedicated to the private Motions. So, Mr Speaker, let us deal with other Businesses that we were already on. We agreed that we will try to exhaust the Statement because many Statements have been advertised. So, if we try to exhaust the Statements in the ensuing week, we can look at all the other issues. Indeed, if we confer at Conclave and we agree on the date that we want to take this Motion, it is important that when we are debating a Motion like this, we have the Central Bank Governor and his team sitting in the Chamber so that they can hear the debate *et cetera*. So, if we fix the date, we can organise and make sure that the Ministry of Finance, the Gold Board team, the Central Bank, and all stakeholders are with us so that we can debate the issues and determine what the facts are and not the allegations that I hear being bandied around.

So, Mr Speaker, I think we should continue with the Business of today.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, I think your application will be put on hold for today.

4:47 p.m.

This morning, I was at the pre-Sitting discussion and actually we did not discuss this. So, my position is that let us hold on with this and discuss it further. Even if we want to take it tomorrow, we have to discuss it. Normally when you are seeking leave, you seek the leave of the House, not necessarily the presiding Speaker. You seek the leave of the House and the House should be in agreement that this what—Hon Members, I am

speaking, so listen to me. You have spoken a lot, so listen to me. Normally when someone seeks leave, the leave should be sought from the House. The Speaker will just look at the situation of the House and probably take a decision.

So, for now my decision is that let us hold on with this application. If tomorrow at pre-Sitting meeting we all agree that we take it, then we can take it tomorrow. But for now, let us hold on with this application.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I do not have a problem. I submit wholly and fully to the ruling and I yield to the orders of the Chair. However, Mr Speaker, since we are a House of records, I just want to put across this point that I rose and mounted my application in good faith. The issue of non-discussion of the matter today in my humble view is very inconsequential in the sense that it had been agreed and full assurances had been given.

Mr Speaker, I have been in that Chair where the Majority Leader is, and sometimes when he is engineering his moves, I understand. He would want to tell a story to put one to sleep. Then when the person wakes up, he says, “oh! my son, you know”—But it is alright. Mr Speaker, it is alright. When my Colleague Leader gives me assurance that next week Thursday, then when Thursday comes, he would say, Leader, you know, the President is coming, so grant me another week. Then I say, it is alright. And then—[*Interruption*—I am referring to my colleague Leader. You are a “Ship”. You were not there. He is

here. Mr Speaker, then again, he assured me in the presence of my Colleagues that this week, we will dedicate Thursday and Friday, and the condition was that for the other two Motions, we will go and see the Speaker. We have not been able to see him.

So, Mr Speaker, I just want the records to reflect that it is not the case that we did not raise it at pre-Setting meeting today and that I am suddenly bringing this matter up. No. I was of the understanding that today we would have it. It is the reason I brought in the applicant. But, Mr Speaker, I will yield to you. I would not want to pursue this matter further. If the Majority Leader, in good faith, says we should prepare for it tomorrow, we will prepare for tomorrow.

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, please—What I said was.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you were not at pre-Sitting and none of them came for pre-Sitting meeting.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I was at pre-Sitting meeting.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, Mr Speaker, you and the First Deputy Speaker were there. But none of them came for pre-Sitting meeting and the understanding as we had already was that we were going to have it today.

Mr Speaker, I will yield to your ruling and comply with same. But I have an understanding from the Majority Leader that we will take this Motion tomorrow. Therefore, Mr Speaker, does that mean that the Minority's Motion must be at the whims and caprices of the Majority? Is that the super Majority approach that when we have a Motion, until they so direct, we cannot have it? Mr Speaker, is that what the Majority Leader is telling the Minority?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I do not think that is the issue. What I said was when we are coming to discuss matters like this, it is better that in the morning before we proceed into the Chamber, we agree that today we will take this. That is my position so that both Sides will be in agreement that is the way we are going to go. So, for this, let us hold on.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, everybody heard me. I said, the Deputy Speakers should get an indication from the Speaker. Is that not what I said? Because as for me, I am ready to debate him any time. But let us have the Speaker give an indication. So, I think that it is not fair for us to go on that tangent and say I have committed to tomorrow. And that is why I said, if we agree on a date, then we can get all the stakeholders to be present. That is what I said. But you see, this is my younger Brother who will always try to find words to put in my mouth. Even when he comes and in the heat of some other engagement, he will make a request and I say, let us look at Thursday or Friday. It does not mean that it will happen on Thursday or Friday. I said, let

us look at Thursday or Friday. There is no agreement that it is Thursday or Friday. But Thursday, when he raised it and then the environment was not conducive, it was not conducive because the President was coming to this House. So, if I said, Thursday or Friday, and Thursday the President was here. Friday, he did not remind me and then he would now come another week and want us to take it—The Thursday or Friday of the week I gave him has passed. So even if he is holding me to my commitment, my commitment was last week Thursday or Friday. That was it.

So, Mr Speaker, I think as you have directed, we will continue with Business for today and then when we meet and we agree on a date at our pre-Sitting meeting, then we will give the necessary notices to all the interested parties to be here for the debate.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I agree; I will not contest this matter but what the Majority Leader has just done to my Colleagues here, it only tells us one thing, hard work. Let us come back to power. Mr Speaker, this is how power is being used. Yes, it is to inspire us. This intimidation, this tossing, it is only one thing; we take power and sit on the right hand of the Speaker.

Mr Speaker, today Majority Leader says he gave indication, when he gave me his word. I am 48 years old. When he tells me something, I know and I believe it. Now he says he did not give indication, Mr Speaker, it only means one thing, hard work from this Side so that we flip about 55 seats—[Hear!

Hear!]

—and take the power and then they will see.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, let me invite Hon Eric Edem Agbana to make his Statement. But I will suspend the House for two minutes.

4:57 p.m. — *Sitting suspended*

5:00 p.m. — *Sitting resumed*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much for your indulgence. Hon Eric Agbana, the floor is yours now.

Need to Upgrade the Ohawu Agricultural College into a Fully-Fledged Agricultural University

Mr Eric Edem Agbana (NDC — Ketu North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this Statement on the need to upgrade the Ohawu Agricultural College into a fully-fledged agricultural university.

Mr Speaker, I rise to draw the attention of this House to the strategic national importance and urgent development needs of Ohawu Agricultural College, one of the six agriculture-focused institutions of higher learning in Ghana.

Established in 1965, Ohawu Agricultural College remains the only agricultural college serving the Volta and Oti Regions and is one of five national agricultural colleges under the Ministry of Food and Agriculture. For nearly six decades, it has trained the backbone of Ghana's middle-level agricultural workforce. Its graduates serve as agricultural extension officers,

field technicians, livestock specialists, and agribusiness practitioners who support food security, livestock development, and rural livelihoods across the country.

Mr Speaker, the college is not only historically significant; it is strategically placed for expansion and modernisation. It occupies over 450 hectares of land and maintains a dedicated staff of 44 serving a student population of 310. The chiefs and people of Afife have further demonstrated community commitment by expressing readiness to provide additional land to support its growth. The institution currently offers certificate, diploma, and HND programmes in General Agriculture and Animal Health and Production, in partnership with the University of Cape Coast and respected international development partners including the Kosmos Innovation Centre, the World Food Programme, and the World University Service of Canada. These partnerships signal clear academic maturity and readiness for elevation.

Notwithstanding this potential, Mr Speaker, the college faces persistent challenges that undermine its mandate. Water supply is inadequate. Lighting and internet connectivity remain insufficient. Staff accommodation and student housing are limited. Lecture halls and furniture are inadequate to support increasing academic demands. In a period defined by digital agriculture, research-led innovation, and global competitiveness, such deficits directly constrain academic excellence, research output, and institutional attractiveness.

Mr Speaker, Ghana cannot continue to under-utilise a facility of this strategic value. Upgrading Ohawu Agricultural College into a fully-fledged agricultural university is not a ceremonial gesture or political token. It is a forward-looking investment in our food security systems, agribusiness competitiveness, and technological preparedness. A university at Ohawu will anchor research in agri-technology, climate-smart agriculture, seed development, livestock improvement, mechanisation, and value-addition. It will strengthen the human capital base required for an agriculture-led, 24-hour productive economy.

As the Member of Parliament for the host constituency, I can attest that the economic multiplier effects will be transformative. University status will expand admissions, attract high-calibre faculty, and stimulate long-term infrastructure development. It will boost transport services, housing, hospitality, commerce, and agro-processing across Ohawu, Abor, Akatsi, and the wider Southern Volta corridor. It will create meaningful opportunities for young people, enhance entrepreneurship, and position Southern Volta as a centre of agribusiness excellence.

Mr Speaker, the vision is clear, the community is aligned, and the opportunity is ripe. Government's stated commitment to upgrading Ohawu Agricultural College must now be accelerated. If we are serious about building a competitive agricultural economy, driving rural industrialisation, and empowering the next generation of

producers and innovators, then this upgrade is essential—not optional.

I therefore respectfully urge the Ministries of Education and Food and Agriculture to expedite the policy, accreditation, and infrastructural processes required to elevate Ohawu Agricultural College to university status. This House must treat this matter as a national development imperative. A stronger agricultural future for Ghana begins with stronger agricultural institutions.

I so submit. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. So, the same rules apply: two from each Side, including Leadership. Let me go to the Hon Member for Offinso North?

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Thank you, Mr Speaker. Let me take this opportunity to also thank the maker of the Statement regarding Ohawu Agricultural College. Mr Speaker, the New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government helped pass the Education Regulatory Bodies Act, 2020 (Act 1023). One would realise that all the agricultural colleges that we have in this country were to be realigned to the Ministry of Education, which I believe is a good policy because that is the Ministry responsible for education and training. We also recognise the specialised nature of agriculture, but the Ministry of Food and Agriculture is supposed to be the sector policy leader and as such, what the NPP Government started: we have the Kwadaso Agricultural College in

Kumasi; Ejura Agricultural College; Damango Agricultural College; Ohawu Agricultural College and the Animal Health and Production College.

Mr Speaker, so Ohawu is not the only agricultural college we need to look at. We need to make sure that we follow up with the policies that were initiated by the previous governments and bring it to fruition. So now, as far as I am concerned, the realignment of these agricultural colleges to the Ministry of Education has not been completed.

5:10 p.m.

So, before we even think about upgrading an institution to a higher education status like a university or a new school, we should first look at the realignment to ensure that this realignment happens, and it does not only happen for one college of agriculture, but all five colleges that were part of the Act 1023.

Mr Speaker, the upgrading of institutions is very important, because we know agriculture employs more people in this country, but it does not reflect in its contribution to the Gross Domestic Product (GDP). So, giving people advanced training in agriculture is something that can improve the efficiency and the effectiveness of its contribution to GDP. And also, it can help us advance, because we are in a technological world where things are changing. How do we even use digital systems to manage our farms? And how

do we ensure that we have enough extension officers to support our cocoa farmers? Even though our cocoa farmers are bleeding, as a nation, how do we get enough extension officers so that most youth in this country can see agriculture as one of the attractive occupations, or appealing enough to attract more young men and women to be in that sector and to be employed as well?

Mr Speaker, unemployment is one of the challenges that we are facing in this country. But upgrading institutions to higher education requires committing to infrastructure. The New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government had initiated the construction of an institution at Bunso for agriculture and engineering. I believe we are going to complete it. Upgrading institutions comes with a lot of commitment, and the Government should make resources available, because some of the schools that have been upgraded to a university status, unfortunately, are not being given the needed resources to function as a higher education institution. We also have some institutions that have already been established. The NPP Government constructed the Local Government University infrastructure, one which is located in Akomadan, another in Tamale, and one in Accra.

Mr Speaker, because the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs is not into the business of education, it tends to lack. So, this House should relook at the issue of

ministries that are not in the business of education running institutions, no matter how specialised in nature the school is, so that this realignment can be done. The Government can commit proper infrastructure investment as well as human capital investment into these institutions. Of course, if we have to upgrade, in that case, the Government has initiated increasing our gross tertiary enrolment ratio. This will be one of the opportunities that we can use to increase our gross tertiary enrolment ratio to also—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You have exhausted your time.

Yes, Majority Side. My Brother, let me hear you.

Mr Ebenezer Alumire Ndebilla (NDC — Zebilla): Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to the Statement ably delivered by my Colleague, Hon Eric Agbana.

Agricultural colleges in our country play a very key role in the agricultural sector as far as knowledge sharing is concerned. And to achieve food security in the country, we have to take technology very seriously, in which the agricultural colleges play a very key role. However, if we go to most of the colleges, what we see there is very pathetic. Most of the institutions do not even have the practical demonstration fields where students can actually acquire the needed knowledge or skills

that are expected of them to be able to deliver services to our teeming farmers. And that is very unfortunate.

Meanwhile, these colleges provide practical training to the graduates who attend these institutions. So, Mr Speaker, I strongly support that not only should we or the Government consider upgrading the Ohawu Agricultural College to a fully-fledged university, but also other agricultural institutions in the country that are running various courses that support our agricultural subsector. So, I rise to support my Colleague and pray that the Government takes this very seriously. Once these institutions provide the needed knowledge that our farmers so much desire, we should, as a matter of urgency, support the institutions with the needed logistics and upgrades so that they can provide the best of services to our graduates who are churned out of these institutions, so that they can provide best services to our farmers to promote agricultural production in the country.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:
Minority Leader.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, let me first commend my Colleague for this bold initiative, bringing an important matter of this nature to this House.

Mr Speaker, I have had the privilege of reading this Statement. He brought me a copy, and particularly in paragraph four of the Statement, he takes time to explain to us the challenges facing the institution. Whatever he said there are facts. My biological dad attended this school. He was one of the early students who studied at Ohawu Agricultural College. He is an agri-mechanic, and he said a lot to me about this school. I know this school, because any time I go to the Volta Region, I use that route to Ho. The last time I visited Hon Agbana's constituency, we drove past that place.

Mr Speaker, we are moving into an era of AI-driven agriculture. It is sad that in the whole of Ghana, we do not have any public university training our children on artificial intelligence (AI). There is no first-degree programme or a master's programme that is powered by AI. We appear to be far away from the advancement that others are experiencing in our world today. So, the call to upgrade this institution to a university is the right call, especially coming from a Member of Parliament from the Volta Region. I think that those of us who have leanings— He is from the Volta Region. His constituency is in the region.

Mr Speaker, grammar is not easy. *[Laughter]* No, that is where I come from, actually. My grandmother comes from Brofoyedru. I think that those of us who are coming from the Volta and Oti Regions should take this very seriously.

And beyond this Statement, come together and present a paper, not only to the Ministry of Food and Agriculture, but to the Ministry of Education. Because if there should be an upgrade to a university status, the right path is the Ministry of Education.

Fortunately, the Hon Member for Akatsi North is the chair of the Committee on Education. So, in Fante, we will say, *eti fufu ma atɔ n'kwan nu mu*.

5:20 p.m.

Mr Speaker, if that one, I want to say it in Ewe, Mr Speaker, then I would have to do a sign [*Laughter*]

Mr Speaker, there will be a better day for me tomorrow. No problem. In other words, it is an opportune time for Members from that part of the region to make a strong case because the agricultural potential in the Volta Region is enormous, but we have not fully explored it and farmers have not received the needed support. I am sure back in the days, this institution was established to support farmers, train technicians and train extension officers to help the farmers. My Daddy tells me about how, in the early days, they had some Germans coming to teach them and how they were prepared for industry and the training they were given abroad — Leaders have more than five minutes. I think my microphone is off.

Mr Speaker, I know about this institution and I do not want this to be one of the Statements that we make on the Floor and we just end it there. Mr Speaker, when this university is established, it is not only going to train students but it is also going to open the economy in that part of the Volta Region. We have a Minister for Roads and Highways from the Volta Region; we have the Minister for Foreign Affairs from the Volta Region and we have the Majority Chief Whip from there.

Mr Speaker, it is an opportunity. This Statement must not be taken as just a two-pager Statement. It is a major door opener for the economy in the Volta Region. Not only agriculture, but also, it will affect the entire value chain; animal husbandry, food production and create opportunities for the youth.

Mr Speaker, many times, we talk about job creation and it becomes mere political talk. This is a practical job creation opportunity we must embrace so that people will not begin to look elsewhere because in that part of Ghana, people still farm without using fertiliser. Proper organic farming takes place there and part of Europe today, people desire organically grown farm produce and they pay premium for it. So, we have to take advantage. Enough of the talk; we have to take advantage.

So, Mr Speaker, we should not take it for granted. I will give him my support, but in opposition, we can only say but we

cannot do. So, for those of them who are in Government, they have the capability of doing the do. Fortunately, some of their Leaders are in Cabinet; take advantage. They may not have this opportunity again tomorrow. They should prove to the people of the Volta Region and the Oti Region that they sent them into this Chamber, they spotted an opportunity and took advantage of it. And that would have a positive effect on the whole national economy, so that when I come back home, I will come proudly that when the time came, I contributed for this to be considered.

Mr Speaker, that said, let me thank Mr Edem Agbana for bringing this to our attention and may this never be kept under any desk. It should go to the Ministry so that action is taken. The President must be informed about this so that Cabinet takes steps quickly to deal with this, for the people of Volta Region to also benefit.

Mr Speaker, that said, let me thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Mr Worlase Kpeli (IND — Kwahu Afram Plains North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, thanks to the Majority Chief Whip for giving me the opportunity to stand in his stead to make a comment on the Statement ably made by Hon Eric Edem Agbana on the upgrading of the

Ohawu Agriculture College into a full-fledged university.

Mr Speaker, I would like to take the angle of specificity and special training for the growth of the economy of Ghana. As a Member of Parliament, whenever we have discussion on the Floor about growing the economy of Ghana in terms of human resources and human power, what baffles my mind is how specific we are in making the efforts to put specialised training that is needed to grow our economy and this is one of the typical examples, like the Ohawu Agricultural College.

In the centre of Ghana's development now, the 24-Hour Economy is agriculture and agribusiness and that is what the Minority Leader has ably stressed on, that in the midst of the 24-Hour Economy and its authority and growth, putting a college like Ohawu Agricultural College into the concept of training specific skill-acquired manpower in agriculture, industrialisation and animal production will be the best to carry Ghana's economy in the space of agriculture and agribusiness. Many of these colleges are scattered around the country, but we keep looking for the specialised skills to harness these efforts in putting Ghana on the highest pedestal of being specialised in some fields, especially in agriculture.

Even in the backyard of Ohawu, in my constituency, Afram Plains, the

Russians and the Japanese helped us to build a fisheries college, which we called Amankwakrom Fisheries and Agricultural Training Institute (AFATI). But all these colleges have been mixed up with other skills so much that the very specific idea for which those colleges were established is no longer in place. We all have the specialties we need to grow our economy but we have them in general knowledge for which we do not have the specific training that will bring out the technicalities that we need in every field.

It is recommended that the Member's Statement be adopted by the House and transmitted, as suggested by the Minority Leader, to Cabinet and the President for consideration and upliftment of the Ohawu Agricultural College into a fully-fledged university.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, we turn to the item numbered 7(g), and the Statement stands in the name of Hon Emmanuel Tobin. *[Pause]*

Please hold on.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, with the Ohawu Agriculture College, I recall that the former Minister for Food and Agriculture, Hon Dr Afriyie Akoto, had a policy of upgrading it. I personally saw the programme here, but it may not have been carried through.

5:30 p.m.

So, I am very happy that Mr Edem Agbana is raising the matter. Mr Speaker, in the entire enclave, apart from the Akatsi College of Education, which is in the capital of the First Deputy Speaker in Akatsi South, there is no other tertiary institution in the entire of the southern Volta Region. Meanwhile, education came to Keta as far back as 1869. So, it is important that a certain tertiary institution of some repute be established. This should kick-start that process. I am very happy that this can be done.

I believe that this is one of the Statements that if Mr Speaker may be minded can be referred to the Committee on Education for them to look at it and bring a Report for purposes of giving some direction regarding elevating the College into a tertiary status, with its consequential effect on the lives of the young people in the area. It will also become a formal institution for training persons in the agricultural sector, especially Extension Officers and all that. So, we can replicate what we have in Akrokeri and Akumadan, Kwadaso and Ejura so that it can be replicated. So that they can be elevated into full-blown tertiary institutions.

Mr Speaker, I am in full support of the call to have this done. I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much for your application for

the referral. Chairperson of the Committee on Education, Hon Peter Nortsu-Kotoe, I am making this referral to you, and I hope it is not going to be as usual. You are going to work on it.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, these days, because of the volume of referrals before Committees, it is part of the guide that when referrers are made, we give them timelines. So, I propose that we give them one week to consider this and return with a Report.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Chairperson of the Committee on Education, you are indicating to me that one week will do. Very well. Within one week, please make a Report to the House and give us directives as to how to proceed to get this thing done.

The referral is accordingly made to the Committee on Education.

Hon Emmanuel Tobbin, we will take your Statement now. You have to floor.

Broken Traffic Lights and Pedestrian Safety in Ghana, with Focus on Anyaa-Sowutuom

Mr Emmanuel Tobbin (NPP — Anyaa-Sowutuom): Mr Speaker, I rise today to bring to the attention of this honorable House a growing road safety concern in many parts of the country, malfunctioning traffic lights and the dangers they pose to both motorists and pedestrians. Across Ghana, broken traffic signals have become a common sight, leading to road congestion, confusion among drivers, and an

increase in accidents. Traffic lights play a critical role in regulating movement on our roads and ensuring the safety of all road users. However, when they stop working, it creates chaos, particularly at busy intersections where pedestrian crossings become extremely risky. This issue is not only a danger to drivers but also a major threat to school children, the elderly, and traders who depend on safe crossings for their daily activities.

Mr Speaker, while this is a nationwide problem, it has become particularly concerning in Anyaa-Sowutuom Constituency. Many communities within the Constituency are struggling with malfunctioning traffic lights, which have led to frequent accidents and traffic congestion.

In addition, recent demonstrations by residents at Awoshie, Abrantie and Anyaa Last Stop highlight the frustration of the people. The protests reflect the growing fear among residents regarding road safety, especially for school children and pedestrians who struggle to cross busy roads due to speeding vehicles and the lack of proper traffic control. One of the most pressing concerns in Anyaa-Sowutuom is the need for pedestrian footbridges at Odorgonno Senior High School, Anyaa Market and Ablekuma Park. These areas are known for high traffic volumes, making it extremely difficult for pedestrians to cross safely.

Mr Speaker, without pedestrian bridges, people especially students are forced to risk their lives by crossing fast-moving vehicles. Unfortunately, this has

led to many accidents, some of which have resulted in tragic fatalities. It is, therefore, necessary to take immediate steps to ensure pedestrian safety in these high-risk zones.

To address these challenges, I recommend the following urgent measures:

Nationwide Repair and Maintenance of Traffic Lights: The Ministry of Roads and Highways, in collaboration with the Department of Urban Roads, must urgently fix broken traffic lights across the country and establish a proper maintenance system.

Enhanced Traffic Management in High-Risk Areas: The Motor Traffic and Transport Department (MTTD) of the Ghana Police Service should deploy officers to regulate traffic at dangerous intersections, particularly in affected communities.

Construction of Footbridges at Odorgonno Senior High School, Anyaa Market and Ablekuma Park: The Ministry of Roads and Highways should prioritise the construction of pedestrian footbridges at these locations to ensure safe crossings.

Public Education on Road Safety: There should be increased awareness campaigns to educate both motorists and pedestrians on the importance of road safety and the proper use of pedestrian crossings.

Mr Speaker, the safety of our roads affects every Ghanaian. While the issue

of malfunctioning traffic lights is a nationwide challenge, the situation in Anyaa-Sowutuom demands immediate attention. I, therefore, call on all relevant authorities to act swiftly to address these concerns, repair our traffic signals, and protect the lives of all road users.

Thank you, Mr Speaker for this opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, again, the rules apply, two from each Side including Leadership. Let me give the opportunity to Member for Parliament for Ho Central.

Mr Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu (NDC — Ho Central): I rise to comment on the Statement made by our Brother, Mr Tobbin. Although he narrowed it to his Constituency, I can conveniently say that every Region in this country has traffic lights. The traffic light in itself is to help us use the road civilly, but our inability to control ourselves, especially the drivers—When they see the yellow or the amber blinking, that is when they begin to speed to cross. Is the amber blinking for you to cross or to move out or to stop? That is one thing they do not know. We also have a responsibility to be regulating them. Some of these people, they say, let us go and come back early. In going and coming back early, that is where they cause their accidents.

Therefore, we need to regulate ourselves, be disciplined on the road, otherwise, no matter how effective the traffic lights are, we will still have these accidents on the road. We have to educate ourselves. We have to take a

critical look at even the driving schools we have in the country, and how they take us through the tutorials for driving in order to get a better scheme. This is so that when people go through that training and come out, they are well placed to teach and also drive well on the streets.

Mr Speaker, let us take this example. Outside the borders of this country, when we see somebody's feet on the zebra crossing, we stop for the person to cross. But here in Ghana, when they see a person even midway the zebra crossing, that is when they speed. Then we ask which driving rules they are applying. We are all living on one earth, but because of indiscipline, we have these things happening and we are doing it to ourselves, not to anybody. Let us become a disciplined people, a disciplined country, then we can live at peace.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for granting me this opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Member for Suaman.

Mr Frederick Addy (NPP — Suaman): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement made by my Colleague, Hon Emmanuel Tobbin.

Traffic lights on our roads must be taken care of. When these traffic lights are broken, the way and manner in which accidents occur on our roads is very

appalling. According to recent research from *GhanaWeb*, about 13 per cent of our traffic lights are working. Also 41 per cent of these traffic lights are partially working and 45 per cent are not working at all.

Sometimes when our school children close from school and they are to even cross the road, it poses a lot of danger. Sometimes a student can stand for about an hour before he crosses the road due to faults with traffic lights. When these cars are speeding, they think they are on the right path, regardless who crosses. Sometimes pedestrians are knocked down because the traffic lights are not functioning. Sometimes our policemen are assigned to those joints in order to control traffic when these policemen should have been at a different joint attending to an equally important assignment if these traffic lights were functioning.

Mr Speaker, when we talk about traffic lights and their repairs, it should not be centred only in Accra. Mostly, the moment traffic lights are mentioned, it is assigned to only Accra and sometimes Kumasi. When we go to our region, especially the newly created regions, Western North, for instance, that is where I come from, Wiawso as the regional capital, does not have a traffic light. Not only Wiawso, but when we go to Bibiani, the way population is increasing is becoming too much. So, when they are attending to traffic lights,

it should not be only centred in our cities, but also the newly created region, especially Western North.

In my constituency, Suaman, Dadieso as well the population is gradually increasing. We urge the Minister for Roads and Highways to attend to those challenges, so that there will be a free movement on our roads in order not to cause any accident.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Minority Leadership. It is two including Leadership so if you would want to yield. Let us hear you.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP — Weija/Gbawe): Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for this opportunity. Let me take this opportunity to commend highly my friend and neighbour, Hon Tobbin, the MP for Anyaa-Sowutuom. Mr Speaker, I am well-versed with some of the issues he is talking about. Particularly, the secondary school in his constituency, Odorgonno Secondary School. A lot of students have lost their lives, just because of the absence of a traffic light at that Odorgonno Secondary School gate. What I am saying is something that has been reported on several occasions, and no action has been taken whatsoever.

We all have issues with traffic lights in our constituencies. In Weija/Gbawe, there is a place called the Broadcasting

Junction. As I speak, the traffic light went off about three or four years now. No action has been taken to remedy how this traffic light went off and nobody has even taken steps to fix it. When we see what is happening with reference to our traffic lights, most are completely non-functional, or are flickering erratically, or sometimes giving the wrong signals. When that happens, it creates a lot of accidents.

The other aspect is that, as we speak, about 2,200 fatalities were recorded in 2023 alone and it was as a result of dysfunctional traffic lights, or the ones which were flickering erratically. Another point that is critical for me is that most pedestrians who are schoolchildren, some are also elderly persons, persons with disabilities, and market traders are disproportionately exposed. Because the moment the traffic light fails to function, we can understand how our schoolchildren and our children cross.

The people with disabilities. We see somebody with a walking stick or crutches and is now compelled to run because the driver who is coming at this person is not sensitive to the person's physical nature. When we have an 83-year-old person who perhaps even has issues with their sight, that is when we see that a driver is coming at such a person. If we do not take steps to correct most of these traffic lights, the incidence of fatalities would abound even more.

This is how it is even more of a problem. Most traffic lights are connected to the national grid. The moment there is *dumsor*, it means that traffic lights are also on *dumsor*. They cease to function. In these modern times, when I had the opportunity of visiting Barcelona and seeing what artificial intelligence (AI) is doing, we would expect that we should be working towards solar, and that when there is no electricity, traffic lights should not be connected to national grid, then when *dumsor* happens the traffic light also goes off. This is a critical point, and we need to look at it. There is so much dependency on national grid for the supply of power to traffic lights. We should depart from that.

Mr Speaker, there is another aspect; vandalism and theft. People go and steal the copper wire and battery units that are supposed to support the traffic lights. When it is time for traffic lights to work, they are not able to work because people have just gone to steal copper wires. All of these are things to consider so that we change the narrative.

When we even give contracts to road contractors to build or construct roads, what is involved in those contracts should be revisited. We should revisit road contracts to ensure that when we give a contract to a road contractor and they are fixing it, which includes a traffic light, we should ensure that the maintenance of that traffic light is upheld. The moment a traffic light is

dysfunctional—just like we have the lifts, although the lifts here, most of them are not working—we should have phone numbers embossed on those traffic lights, connecting the road contractors. The moment the traffic light ceases to perform or function, the road contractor is called to come and fix the traffic light.

5:50 p.m.

I think that traffic light is a matter we should consider seriously. We should not look at it from only Hon Tobin's point of view. Every district should have a system or a structure managing its traffic lights. We should empower road contractors and ensure that contracts that are signed with reference to traffic lights are managed and maintained properly. Mr Speaker, let me go back to Hon Tobin and Odorgonno Senior High School. It is a major problem, Mr Speaker, let us take action on this matter. No student who has gone to school should lose his or her life just because of the recklessness of a driver and the absence of a traffic light.

Mr Speaker, with this, I want to take this opportunity to say thank you once again.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me commend Hon Tobin for this because it is such a major crisis on our roads. Often, the contracts that we award for the construction of highways come with the installation of road infrastructure, which includes the installation of traffic lights, street lights, and road markings. The road markings are not often done after

the road is done. The street lights are not often provided; it takes the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition to go back and get MPs to buy poles to install street lights. Then, the traffic lights are sometimes installed, but as soon as they break down in the first instance, that is the end.

As I speak, the entire Eastern Corridor, the stretch that covers my Constituency from Asikuma to Kpeve, which is about 18.9 km, has no single traffic light. One of my major communities, Peki Tsame, where we have the government hospital, is located to the left of the highway when we are driving from Accra, and the community is mainly sited at the right-hand side. So, there is brisk movement of the people across the highway to access the hospital. Just a couple of weeks ago, there was a major accident involving a knockdown of some of the pedestrians from the community, sometimes even patients. And the community has been struggling. We have been calling for the installation of traffic lights. The Ghana Highway Authority (GHA) is not paying heed to this. At the intersection within the district capital, which is Kpeve itself, there is a need for the installation of a traffic light. It is not done, and there have been accidents as a result. When we get to Asikuma, which is like the nerve centre for the Eastern Region and the Volta Region, we have two security barriers. In fact, three barriers: the Ghana Immigration Service (GIS) barrier, the Customs barrier, and the Narcotics Control Commission (NACOC). Now, the Forestry Commission has brought its checkpoint, yet there is no traffic light,

and accidents continue to happen at the Asikuma junction. So, the installation of traffic lights is such a major call.

Mr Speaker, what we have forgotten is that it is not the speed ramps that check speeds, and it is not the rumble ramps; it is rather traffic lights. Because often, when every reasonable driver sees that the traffic light is red, they will stop. They will slow down and stop for the green to come on before they continue. If we see a traffic light from afar, it is visible, illuminated, and we are educated about it. But instead of getting traffic lights to work, we would rather want to mount speed ramps, and when a driver is a first timer on such a major road and is not aware that there is such a major speed ramp, they would rather get involved in an accident. This is because they rush into it, crash into it, and an accident occurs.

So, Mr Speaker, this is a very simple Statement, but it is such a major Statement that I think, if you would accept my prayer, it should be referred to the Committee on Roads and Transportation for them to look at. So that where it is critical that these traffic lights are replaced, there will be a major call from Parliament directed at the Ministry of Transport or Roads and Highways to act as a matter of urgency. In consideration of this Statement, if it is determined that it is the metro assemblies that should have some responsibility, then the assemblies can be directed. Because it appears we do not even know who should sponsor the installation of the traffic lights. Therefore, we think that for maintenance, the assemblies will do

it, and the assemblies think that the Road Fund officials will do it. The Road Fund officials think that the Minister of Transport will be responsible, or the National Road Safety Authority will do it. So, the traffic light breaks down, and we do not know whose responsibility it is to go and maintain it.

I pray that you refer this Statement to the appropriate Committee, for them to look at it quickly, so that Parliament can give some directives in this matter. Because it will be a major source of ensuring that safety on our roads improves. Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Chairperson and Ranking Member for the Committee on Roads and Transportation are not here. I hope some Members are here. Do we have any Members here?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we would give them a week.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I just wanted to see whether I could find some of the Members of the Committee here.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, what is important is that the referral is made. Leadership will bring it to the attention of the Committee Leaders.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Table Office, please bring it to the attention of the Chairperson, the Ranking Member, and Members of the Committee that they should look at this

Statement and report to the House within a week. I so direct.

Hon Members, we will take two more Statements. One of our former Hon Members of Parliament has passed on to eternity. I would therefore invite the Member of Parliament for Odododiodioo, Hon Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie, to make a Statement in memory of Hon Nii Okaija Adamafio.

Hon Member, you have the floor now.

Tribute to the Late Hon Nii Okaija Adamafio

Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (NDC — Odododiodioo): Mr Speaker, with a heavy heart, I rise to thank you for the honour done me on behalf of the good people of Odododiodioo to read this Statement in memory of the late Hon Nii Okaija Adamafio.

Mr Speaker, the late Hon Nii Okaija Adamafio was a distinguished statesman, a legal practitioner who played a significant role in Ghana's transition to the Fourth Republic. Renowned for his steadfast commitment to the then Provisional National Defence Council (PNDC) and the National Democratic Congress, Hon Adamafio devoted over three decades of his life to public service.

The late Hon Nii Okaija Adamafio was born in Accra on 5th October, 1945, to his late parents, Tawia Adamafio, a former Minister of State under Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah's regime, and Caroline Adamafu, a trader. He was

married and blessed with three children. Mr Speaker, Hon Adamafio received his early education at the Government Boys School, Kinbu in Accra. When his family relocated to Osu in 1956, he continued his education at Salem Presbyterian Middle Boarding School.

6:00 p.m.

In 1959, he successfully passed the Common Entrance Examination and was admitted to Laboni Secondary School where he completed his secondary school in 1964. Demonstrating remarkable determination from an early age, Hon Adamafio worked during the day at the Ghana General Post Office in Accra while attending the Accra Workers College in the evening to further his studies. His perseverance yielded results when he successfully passed his advanced level examination in 1966, gaining admission to the University of Ghana, Legon where he studied Philosophy, Political Science, and History.

During his time at the university, he was affiliated with Commonwealth Hall and was actively involved in student politics. Upon graduating with a Bachelor of Arts degree in 1970, he proceeded to teach in several institutions including Accra Polytechnic, now Accra Technical University, Laboni Secondary School, and Salem Secondary School. He also served as a clerical officer at the Ghana Post and Telecommunications Corporation.

In pursuit of his long-standing interest in the legal profession, Hon

Adamafio returned to the University of Ghana, Legon in 1972 to study Law. He completed his studies in 1975 and was awarded an LLB degree and subsequently proceeded to the Ghana School of Law at Makola. Upon completion of his professional training, he was called to the Bar in 1977.

Mr Speaker, after his call to the Bar, Hon Adamafio practised at Afroso Chambers with his father and took over as master of chambers following the retirement of his father in 1982. Renowned for his sharp intellect, commanding courtroom presence, Hon Adamafio earned a reputation as one of the most formidable criminal advocates of his time and a respected force within the legal profession.

Mr Speaker, in addition to making significant strides in his legal career, Hon Adamafio was a prominent and influential politician, playing a key role from the Provisional National Defence Council (PNDC) era until his passing. His contribution and leadership during this pivotal time were instrumental in shaping the political landscape. Within the PNDC, Hon Adamafio held several executive positions including the Greater Accra Regional Secretary, Coordinator for Revenue Commissioners, Acting Secretary at the Ministry of the Interior, and Deputy Secretary at the Ministry of the Interior. He also held other positions during this era including Member of the Peace Council, Member of the Prisons Service Council, Chairman of the Greater Accra Coordinating Council, and Chairman of the Regional Security Committee.

In 1991, when the PNDC government announced a return to constitutional rule, Hon Nii Okaija Adamafo played a key role in the formation of the Every Ghanaian Living Everywhere (EGLE) Club, a social club that facilitated political mobilisation and included notable figures like the late Samuel Teiko Quarshie, Mr R. O. Akai Nettey, many of whom were of Ga origins. The late Hon Adamafo was regarded as the link between the revolutionary foundations of the PNDC and the democratic principles of the National Democratic Congress (NDC). He was respected for his discipline and ability to navigate political landscapes.

As a stalwart, Hon Adamafo held several executive positions within the NDC including serving Chairman of the Greater Accra Regional Caucus, Acting Chairman and National Vice Chairman of the NDC. In these roles, Hon Adamafo mentored young politicians and actively participated in organising grassroots campaigns. Representing the Odododiodioo Constituency, a key political battleground in the heart of Accra, as a Member of Parliament from January 1997 to January 2001, Hon Adamafo was known for his sharp, often confrontational, but highly intellectual debating style.

His influence in the Ga-Mashie area made him a significant voice for the people of the capital. He was a vocal advocate for the development of Old Accra. He frequently pushed for urban renewal projects and the legal empowerment of local assemblies to manage Accra's growing infrastructural

needs. Hon Adamafo's most famous speeches often centred on the Public Order Act. He famously defended the stance of the government on maintaining national stability during the early volatile years of the Fourth Republic, arguing that, "Liberty must be balanced with the collective peace of the Ga state and the nation".

In recognition of his competence and experience, Hon Adamafo was appointed Minister for the Interior in February 1997 by His Excellency, the late former President John Jerry Rawlings. In this role, Hon Adamafo was responsible for national security, policing, and internal stability during the formative period of Ghana's young democracy. He worked on modernising the Ghana Police Service. In his role as the Minister for the Interior, on 5th January, 2001, Hon Adamafo authored and signed critical executive orders, such as the Deportation (Revocation) Order, 2001 (E.I. 1), which handled high-profile matters of national sovereignty and legal status of foreign nationals within Ghana.

While Hon Adamafo had stepped back from the front line of active daily politics in recent years as a result of ill health, his counsel was frequently sought by some party leaders. While he is often remembered as a powerhouse within the NDC, his background as a legal practitioner and his legislative contributions provided a fuller picture of his impact on Ghanaian statecraft and the development of the Ga state.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, as we mourn the passing of Hon Okaija

Adamafio, we also recognise with sympathy and respect the weight of the loss on his family and loved ones. On behalf of the people of Odododiodioo, whom I have the privilege to serve, I extend heartfelt condolences to his family and all who were touched by his life and service. May the soul of the late Nii Okaija Adamafio rest in perfect peace, and may his service continue to guide and inspire us.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Member.

Yes, let me invite Hon Bede Zeideng.

Mr Bede Anwataazumo Ziedeng (NDC — Lawra): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to pay tribute to my very good Friend, the late Nii Okaija Adamafio.

Nii Okaija Adamafio was a lawyer and a politician. Indeed, he bounced onto the political scene during the era of the PNDC, when he was first appointed as the Secretary for the Interior. That was when I met him, and we related very well. Subsequently, he was appointed Coordinator for Tribunal as additional responsibility, and I continued to work with him.

6:10 p.m.

Indeed, Mr Speaker, in the run-up to the 1992 elections, when political parties were being formed, Nii Okaija, as a political strategist, came up with the idea of the EGLE Club, and then we started

operating, and in fact, I was part of the initial Every Ghanaian Living Everywhere (EGLE) club, and we started operating in the various regions. We worked hard, then the NDC won the 1992 elections and we were ushered into government. He was subsequently appointed as presidential staffer and he continued in that position until 1996 when he contested the Odododiodioo seat, won it and came into Parliament. Mr Speaker, he did four years and unfortunately in the 2000 election, there was a tsunami and that tsunami affected him because that was the year in which we had in the NDC what we call the imposition of MPs. Parliamentary candidates had their names announced from the Castle and then there was so much uproar about it. The wind came and blew off as many as a hundred parliamentary candidates. That is how come the NDC went into opposition.

Mr Speaker, after the 2000 elections, the NDC had to reorganise itself and so as a result of the reorganisation, Hon Nii Okaidja Adamafio offered himself as a contestant for the national vice-chairmanship. So, he stood and he won. I also stood as deputy general secretary and I also won. So, we worked together at the national headquarters and we were so effective that the Kufuor Government initially thought that they were going to have an easy ride, but by the end of 2004, they were so scared that the then Chief of Staff had to rush to the Castle to go and announce the results of the 2004 elections ahead of what the Electoral Commissioner would do. *[Laughter]* That is how much scare we put into them and I am saying that we worked very

well. Unfortunately, we did not win the 2004 elections and subsequently we had challenges, which is now history.

But Nii Okaidja Adamafio continued to be my friend. We continued to relate and we related very well. In fact, when he fell sick, I visited him on his sickbed and had a discussion with him. We thought that he would recover and then come back. Unfortunately, that did not happen and today, we have to pay tribute to him for the loss of his life.

Mr Speaker, on this occasion, I would like to pay my respects to Nii Okaidja Adamafio and convey my condolences to the bereaved family, and in fact, to the NDC as a party and also to all his friends. We were friends and we all worked together. I must say that we have lost a great man. This was a great politician. He was a strategist. He was somebody who could think and let me add that, in fact, he provided—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Yes, Leadership?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, let me crave your indulgence to contribute to this Statement. As I do so, respectfully, if I am permitted, let me come under Order 63 and speak a bit of Ga to my Ga people. Mr Speaker, with your permission, *ke wɔ tse, wɔ nuntsɔ etse bo le, yaawɔ ojogbanɲ; yaawɔ ojogbanɲ ejaake, oha ni Ga man mu le fɛɛ ena ake oba ni obasumɔ. Otsu nɔ ni sa, otsu nɔ ni wa. Ni ojweɲ manbii ahe.* To wit, may his soul rest in perfect peace. When he had the opportunity to serve, he served well.

He supported his Ga people and he helped them to build whatever opportunities they had to.

Mr Speaker, Nii Okaidja Adamafio was the indicator for the 2000 elections, like Hon Bede Ziedeng said. The moment he lost, we, the New Patriotic Party, were able to tell that we had won that election. He was a stalwart within the Ga politics, and he would teach that he came from the revolutionary era to the NDC era so he had all the features that were needed for him to show that he was in charge. Mr Speaker, he was also the Minister for the Interior, and he made us understand that power means power. He never joked with power.

Mr Speaker, he also had the opportunity of helping a lot of the Ga youth, especially the Ga-Mashie boys. Those who had the qualification to be recruited into the Police Service, he ensured that they got there. At that point, he was not thinking of taking GH¢220 from them. He never also gave them aptitude tests to write. *[Laughter]* He ensured that whatever was due them, he helped them to get there. Fortunately, today some of them have become senior officers in the Police Service and other security services. Today, if Nii Okaidja Adamafio is no more, when you go to the Lands Commission, he also served as the regional chair of the Lands Commission, and he put a lot of solid structures in place. To the extent that we would not find people taking government lands without reference to proper structures.

Mr Speaker, today we are here to say that a lot of Ga young men have taken a

cue from Hon Nii Okaidja Adamafio, a very humble but straightforward person. He was also very strict. When I was growing as a young man, anytime I saw Nii Okaidja Adamafio coming, I found another route because one would never know what he could do to the person. We know that those times, most young men would be wearing their jeans down and they call it *Otofista*. One could do that in front of Nii Okaidja Adamafio. He was a strong disciplinarian and a stout party person. That was where he sometimes fell short, because for whatever it is worth, he wants to consider his party people largely. But today, he is no more, and we from the Ga community have lost a mighty oak tree. A tree that we can forever say that he supported the Ga community, and we are still looking for a seeming replacement of Nii Okaidja Adamafio when it comes to strictness. Mr Speaker, may his soul rest in perfect peace. Nii Okaidja Adamafio, *nuumo ya wɔ ojogbaɲɲ, wɔ ojogbaɲɲ kɛ wɔ kpe ekone bɛɛ nitsɔɔ akɛ ekolɛ mi hu miye* Minister for the Interior *ni minke bo mba ni wɔ gba sane tswa ni omanyɛ abla wɔ*. To wit, old man, rest well. The next time we meet, I would have been the Minister for the Interior coming to have a conversation with you. May good fortune come. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Majority Leadership? You are yielding to—Very well.

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah (NDC — Ho West): Thank you, Mr Speaker. As I contribute to the memory of the late Hon Nii Okaidja Adamafio, let me congratulate and commend my

Brother, the MP for Odododiodioo for bringing this to the fore. When we were young, during the revolution time, the name we heard was Nii Okaidja Adamafio, a man who we all knew was one of the instrumentalities when it came to the revolution. He pioneered a lot of issues when it came to the Ga state, and no wonder he was made the Minister for the Interior when we came to the democratic rule.

6:20 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I was young then, working with Architecture and Engineering Services Limited then, which is now AESL as a young quantity surveyor, and we were asked to give an estimate to the Minister for the Interior at that time, and I went there with my seniors to measure the place for the estimate.

Mr Speaker, that was the first time I met the late Nii Okaidja Adamafio. He was someone who liked laughing. For those who knew him, he was always smiling. There was no anger in him at all, unlike some people who carried themselves as leaders of this nation. In those days, as soon as we met some of them, the frown alone told us that they carried power. But this late Nii Okaidja Adamafio was a jovial person, smiling all the time.

Mr Speaker, going through my Colleague's tribute, I realised that he has done very well to the extent that when he was even working in Accra, he decided

to go back to school and attend the Accra Workers' College, where he earned his A-level and decided to enrol himself at law school and became a lawyer, an astute lawyer in this country. Young people should learn from this that if they are unable to complete their West African Senior School Certificate Examination (WASSCE) level, that is not the end of life. They can be working while enrolling themselves in school so they can become what they want to be in life. The late Okaidja Adamafio became a lawyer, and I believe one of the reasons the late Jerry John Rawlings appointed him as, first of all, Greater Accra Secretary and later the Deputy and then Minister for the Interior was the fact that he went to school and became a lawyer in that era.

Today, we commiserate with the family, but also learn from the steps that he has left. The Ga state has lost a great man, the nation has lost a great man, the National Democratic Congress (NDC) fraternity has lost a great man, and all we can say is that may his soul rest in perfect peace. May the children and those that he has left behind remember that their father has paid his dues, he has played his role as a statesman in this country, and he has contributed his quota to the nation of Ghana.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, may we respectfully rise and

give a minute's silence in prayer to his memory.

[A minute's silence was observed.]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: May the soul of Hon Nii Okaidja Adamafio and the souls of all past Members of this House rest in perfect peace.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we have two more Statements: one for Hon Suhuyini and Hon Zuwera.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, we cannot take all of them.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, on the *Order Paper*, we ought to have taken Hon Zuwera first, but at the time that we began, she had stepped out on some other duties. So, we began with item numbered 7(b). So, she has been patiently waiting to have her bite.

Mr Speaker, in the meantime, before we do that, if I may bring to your attention this matter in respect of a referral made on 5th November, 2025. On that Wednesday, the Annual Report of the Audit Committee of the Ghana Geological Survey Authority for 2024 was laid in the House. Procedurally, it ought to be referred to the appropriate Committee. But inadvertently, the referral was made to the Committee on Information and Communications. However, in pursuance of Order 240, the Committee that has the mandate to consider this Report is the Committee on

Lands and Natural Resources because it is an entity under the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources.

So, my prayer is that the referral be reversed so that a fresh one be made to the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources for their consideration and report to plenary.

Mr Speaker, I humbly pray.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Your prayer, I think, is well placed. So that referral is withdrawn, and same is accordingly referred to the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources for consideration and report.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, consequentially, the advertised meeting by the Committee on Information and Communications in respect of this matter, slated for tomorrow, will have to be—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, based on this, it has no effect.

Mr Dafeamekpor: So, the Committee leadership should take note.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, are we going to take the two Statements?

Mr Dafeamekpor: The sense of the House is that we do take them, but before we do, may I pray that we lay two Papers under items numbered 8(c) and (e), just

to lay the reports of these two committees. So, the first one is by the Chairperson of the Committee for Education.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, let us turn to page 4, item numbered 8(c).

PAPERS

By Chairperson of the Committee—

Report of the Committee on Education on the Education Regulatory Bodies (Amendment) Bill, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, we turn to page number 5, the item numbered 8(e).

Dr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu: Mr Speaker, respectfully, the Chairperson is not around, and I am the Ranking Member of the Committee.

By Dr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu on behalf of the Chairperson—

Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Education Regulatory Bodies (National Teaching Council) Regulations, 2025.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we therefore have to come back to item numbered 7(a).

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah, you may take your Statement, but again, hold on for me to suspend the House for two minutes.

6:29 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

6:30 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

So, Hon Zuwera, you may take the floor.

STATEMENT

Tribute in Honour of Hon Hajia Mary Salifu Boforo

Mr Speaker, I rise to read this Statement in memory of one of the female trailblazers in politics from the northern part of Ghana. Permit me, Mr Speaker, to preface the Statement with an admonition from the almighty Allah that indeed to Allah we belong and to him we shall return. *Innalilayi wa Innalilayi ra'juon!*

Mr Speaker, I rise with a heavy heart, yet profound gratitude to pay tribute to the late Hon Hajia Mary Salifu Boforo, former Member of Parliament for Savelugu Constituency from 1997 to 2013, who departed this life on 13th December, 2025.

Mr Speaker, the passing of Hon Hajia Boforo represents not merely the loss of a distinguished parliamentarian but the dimming of a beacon that illuminated the

path for women's leadership in northern Ghana.

Mr Speaker, at a time when the corridors of power in our region were the exclusive preserve of men, Hon Hajia Boforo, alongside pioneering women such as the late Hon Hawa Yakubu of Bawku Central and Hon Alima Mahama of Nalerigu Gambaga, defied convention and broke through barriers that had stood for generations.

Mr Speaker, these trailblazers demonstrated extraordinary courage in stepping into spaces where their presence was questioned, their competence doubted, and their voices often dismissed.

Mr Speaker, rising to become the First Deputy Majority Whip and Chairperson of Ghana's Parliamentary Women's Caucus, Hon Hajia Boforo championed the empowerment of women and children, boldly declaring that, and I quote:

“The fight for equality between men and women goes beyond the case made for social justice, but rather a fundamental human right that must be achieved.”

Mr Speaker, I stand here today as a direct beneficiary of her sacrifice and fortitude. The seat I occupy in this august House was made possible because women like Hon Hajia Boforo refused to accept that leadership was a male

birthright. They proved through service that competence, dedication, and vision know no gender.

Mr Speaker, as we mourn Hon Hajia Boforo's passing, let us also celebrate her life of purpose and impact. Her name still echoes in the corridors of our Parliament, consistently associated with discipline, diligence, and compassion. I draw immense pride from hearing such tributes, for her legacy and example have profoundly shaped my own understanding of parliamentary work and conduct. Let us honour her memory by ensuring that the doors she held open remain open, and that more women from the north, and indeed from across our beloved nation, continue to ascend to positions of leadership.

Mr Speaker, she was a household name throughout the Northern Region. As a young student working in community development, Savelugu was among my project areas, and there I witnessed firsthand the transformative impact of her service. Every grinding mill I encountered bore witness to her dedication to the women of Savelugu. Every borehole carried her footprints, installed to ease the burdens of her constituents. The women were her priority, and she gave expression to this commitment through tireless action. Her connection to her constituency was both special and admirable.

May *Allah Subhanahu wa ta'ala* grant her soul Jannatul Firdaus.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

So, Hon Kobby Darko.

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr Speaker, for those of us who have been in this House for some time, have had the special privilege of interacting and engaging with Hajia Boforo. For us on this Side, she had always been someone who had time for us. In fact, her usual chocolate sharing in this House was very spectacular. Hajia Boforo, we all know, was the MP for Savelugu, and I had my Constituency executive, who also hailed from Savelugu, and they used to speak so well of her.

Mr Speaker, we also know that she empowered a lot of women in her constituency. We know that a lot of the infrastructure, like boreholes, electricity connections, and the rest, were done through her effort.

Mr Speaker, for the likes of Hajia Boforo to rise to the level of a First Deputy Majority Whip, I believe that it shows consistently that Ghanaian women can do so much for our country. I know that my own predecessor was the Deputy Leader in this House for some

time. We have had other women who have also done so well for this Parliament, like Ms Cecilia Dapaah, Madam Frema Opare, and the rest, and I believe that her effort in this House, and her ability to stay here, showed that there is nothing beyond a woman to be able to serve her country.

Mr Speaker, one other thing about Hajia Boforo was that she was always smiling. That made it easy for those of us on the other Side to connect. We knew she had a good heart, and like we know, there is always a season for everything, and when she lost her seat, a lot of us were shocked that the NDC could not keep her seat for her to come back to the House.

With this, Mr Speaker, we say rest in peace, Hajia Boforo.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me come to Mr Sanja Nanja.

Mr Sanja Nanja (NDC — Atebubu/Amantin): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement that was ably made by the Hon Member for Salaga South.

Mr Speaker, Hajia Boforo's compassion and generosity, especially for the First Timers and Members of Parliament in general, I should say, was very legendary. This was a woman who had the welfare of First Timers at heart. When we met her in the Sixth

Parliament, she really made us feel at home. Our welfare matters were so important to her that on most of the sitting days, whether extended or not extended, she invited us almost every day to her office for lunch. She was always ready to share the little that she had with us in terms of advice or finance.

6:40 p.m.

This was a woman who sometimes would approach you and ask when was the last time you went to the constituency. And if you say, two or three weeks, she would ask whether it is about resources. She would ask you to come to her office and when you go, she would give you money and tell you to visit the constituency. On Tuesday, she will come and ask you whether you were able to go. Sometimes, some of us felt very ashamed going to her office, but she would still come and pull us to go and take lunch. Before you get there, other Colleagues will be there, including even former Members who had lost their elections. On weekends, we would go to her office and you would see her coming with envelopes to give money to former MPs. This was a woman who was really a mother.

Mr Speaker, I wish Parliament could do something to immortalise Hajia Boforo. Hajia Boforo will always remain in our hearts. Thank you, Mr Speaker.
[Hear!] [Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Yes, I guess you are taking it for Leadership. Let me give it to you because you are an old-timer and might have encountered her.

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah (NDC — Ho West): Mr Speaker, let me commend my Sister, Hajia, for this tribute on behalf of the good people of Savelugu and in the memory of our late Sister, Hajia Boforo. Mr Speaker, myself and Hon Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah met her in 2009 in this House. That was almost 18 years ago. For a woman to have gone through as Member of Parliament for five good terms, I think she has broken the record. I have not heard of any woman who has broken that record. The highest we have had so far is this fifth-timer, who is Hajia Boforo. No woman in this House has broken that record. All the women either end in their third term or fourth term. Currently, we have fourth-timers who are women.

Coming from the Northern Region which we all know to be more patrilineal than matrilineal, where women are not seen in the forefront of leadership, Hajia Boforo has been a Member of Parliament for that number of years, bracing all the odds, beating all the men to have won five consecutive times, clearly shows that she is a woman of substance. Our young ladies should learn from that experience.

Mr Speaker, just as my other Colleagues mentioned, we met her in this House and she is a very generous

woman. I was fortunate to have met her because my predecessor, the late Hon Agbotse, whom I took over from, was her mate when they came to this House. So, the first person he told me to meet was Hajia Boforo, his classmate. So when I came, I looked for her and because of that relationship between her and the late Hon Agbotse, I became very close to her. Just as my other Colleagues, we go to her office most often, especially in those days when we had extended Sittings. She was the one who was in charge of our welfare matters. Today, we do not see our Hon Members, ladies, taking care of our welfare as Hajia Boforo used to do.

Mr Speaker, being the Deputy Whip at that time, her generosity cut across and I heard my Colleague from the other Side mentioned it. She is the one who will take care of you, both in terms of chocolates and everything that you need. When she became the leader of the Women Caucus, she did take care of the women as well. Even when she was sharing cloth those days, we the men even go to her office and we get our share for our wives. We have lost such a nice woman. We were thinking that she will come for the sixth term, but fate has its own way. Even though Hajia Boforo was old in age, when you look at her, she was very active and proactive. Her memory was so sharp. When you ask her questions about parliamentary proceedings and parliamentary processes, she is able to tell you what to do and what not to do. More especially,

when it comes to interaction with one's constituents, that has been her strongest strength. She said if you really want to maintain your seat and come back to this House, you need to be in touch with your constituents. She has taught almost all of us, especially those of us who came in 2009. She has taught us that we need to be in touch with our constituents to make sure that we return to the House. We have lost a beautiful woman. We have lost a gem. We have lost one of the astute Members of Parliament.

I want to add my voice to what my Colleague Hon Sanja Nanja said that we need to immortalise her, even if it is just one block that we can name after her — that this is the late Hon Hajia's Boforo's block in this House, that will go a long way to get our young ladies to do what Hajia Boforo had done. With these few words, Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. Let me also thank Hon Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah for the tribute she just read. Mr Speaker, I join Colleagues to eulogise Hon Boforo. I entered this House in 2013. At that time, Members had no office space, so we used to hang around the Foyer. We picked our documents in the mails room and stood at the Foyer to read them. So, our car boots became our library and everything. Those days, her office used to be on the first floor on the new block. Every lunchtime, we used to go there and she

would serve us. It got to a point; I became a registered member in her office. Even if I do not go for lunch, she would send somebody to come and call me to come and eat. Whether I liked it or not, I had to take whatever was available then.

Mr Speaker, if you enter my living room, I have a very beautiful picture with Hajia Boforo. If you do not know my wife, you may suspect she is my wife. *[Laughter]*

It is so beautiful. My wife initially was fighting with me because how can we—*[Laughter]* No, the way the picture is so beautiful and how the cameraman took the picture— So beautiful, and I am still keeping it in my living room.

Mr Speaker, something happened on the Floor here. At the time, Hon Inusah Fuseini was the Minister for Roads and Highways. I filed a Question about Adabokrom – Nkwanta Road. The technical people provided wrong answers for the minister to come and answer. So, I was so angry. At the time, we were in Government. I went after the minister. I was a young MP then and the energy was so high like what Jerry is doing now. *[Laughter]* We have gone past that stage.

I went after the minister. After that, she accosted me and said “Hon Member, what did you do? Have you forgotten you are in Government? Why did you embarrass the Minister?” I gave her all

the reasons for which I did what I did. She said “Do not worry. Let us go to my office”.

We called Dr Opuni around 12:00 midnight to 1:00 a.m. Mr Ato Forson was at the time, the Deputy Minister for Finance. He asked me what happened in Parliament and I gave them the rundown. The next day, the contractor was on site. *[Laughter]*

6:50 p.m.

So, they asked me what I wanted. I told them to give me a six-unit classroom block and fix Adabokrom Nkwanta road. As I speak, the school is there and children are benefiting from it. The road was awarded through the intervention of Hajia Boforo. So, from there, she told me,

“Hon Member, if you want certain things to be done for you, do not be aggressive. Just come to me and we will deal with it.” This is Hajia.

So, Mr Speaker, let me join Colleagues and pray that Allah should receive her soul. May Allah bless her.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, under normal circumstances, since my Colleague has made those remarks, that should be the end of the Statement. But I do not want us to end on a sad note. It is important to end on a very sweet, beautiful note.

Today happens to be the 75th birthday of the former First Lady of the Republic of the Land. *[Hear! Hear!]* She is 75 years today. Mrs Rebecca Victoria Naa Okaikor Akufo-Addo—*[Hear! Hear!]*—I am not done. Madame Rebecca Victoria Naa Okaikor Akufo-Addo is a very compassionate woman. She served effortlessly with grace and was a very brilliant support to her husband.

Today, if she is 75 years, we beg to say that we wish her well. We pray that she lives longer and more beautifully so that Hon Rockson and I can still go and visit her when she is 90 and sitting at the beach somewhere in—not anywhere around Iran, but somewhere in Prampram. Mr Speaker, thank you very much for indulging me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We wish Mrs Victoria Akufo-Addo very well. But before then, Hon Members, may you rise and as usual, give one minute respect in prayer to Hajia Mary Salifu Boforo.

[A minute's silence was observed]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: May the soul of Hajia Mary Salifu Boforo and the soul of all departed, especially those who served in this Chamber, rest in perfect peace.

Hon Members, we will take the last Statement. For that, I will take only one comment from each Side. The Statement is coming from—Yes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: I do not want this to be unidirectional. So let me join my Brother, Hon Jerry Ahmed, to wish the former First Lady a very happy 75th birthday. We wish her all the best. She is my auntie too. I have said so. It is not in question. So, when it is in question, they will be begging for it. Everybody knows who Auntie Rebecca is, and her commitment to ensuring that those of us who serve in public service, especially those who served with their husband, did their best. She is still supporting the old man to be able to manage matters and affairs of state. So, we wish her all the best.

On behalf of the House and leadership, we want to convey our congratulatory message to her for attaining 75 years. We pray that God grants her more life and she grows to be 100 years. So that we can celebrate that with her.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Joseph Kwame Kumah, you will take the last Statement. You have the floor now.

Urgent Call to Establish a Health Security Fund for Ghana

Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (NDC — Kintampo North): I thank you Mr Speaker for this opportunity to rise and speak on behalf of the good people of Kintampo North, home of one of only three health research centres established by the Ghana Health Service, the Kintampo Health Research Centre.

Mr Speaker, in the last thirty years, Ghana has seen the outbreak of multiple diseases and has experienced myriads of man-made and natural disasters. From 2020 to 2023, we have been hit with COVID-19, Yellow fever, Monkeypox, Marburg virus and Measles Outbreaks. In July 2024, the emergence of Dengue Fever posed a potential threat, alongside a cholera outbreak affecting five regions of Ghana, as well as reports of increased cases of Acute Respiratory Infections, particularly attributed to human Metapneumovirus (hMPV) in China and the Northern Hemisphere. This demonstrates disease outbreaks' unpredictability and capacity to inflict devastating consequences.

In addition, natural disasters such as flooding with their associated public health threats and impacts have become nearly perennial in Ghana. Non-communicable diseases also now account for 74 per cent of deaths while road accidents led to 2,276 deaths in 2023 alone. Between January and September 2024, 1,817 lives were lost due to road accidents, representing an increase of 8.35 per cent in fatalities compared to the same period in 2023. These statistics emphasise Ghana's health security threats and the urgent need for policies and sustainable domestic funding mechanisms to address them.

For example, in the wake of the pandemic influenza, an illustrative study of the perceived adequacy of

preparedness of sub-Saharan Africa used Ghana's 2009 to 2013 integrated strategic response plan for pandemic influenza as a case study, and the results revealed that "Ghana's health emergency preparedness is in disarray".

It further revealed that three out every four health facilities did not have emergency preparedness plans, surge capacity planning, triage system for mass health emergencies, and mutual aid agreements.

Mr Speaker, current domestic funding for preparedness and response to public health emergencies and other health security threats is inadequate with heavy reliance on external donor support and loans. During health emergencies, countries without a reliable domestic funding mechanisms like Ghana, often face severe impacts and must rely on contingency funds or donor assistance, which have proven insufficient. In light of the prevailing dynamics of global politics, particularly the United States' withdrawal from the World Health Organization and its subsequent implications, it is essential for Ghana to prepare for a decrease in external donor support related to health security. Therefore, this situation demands an increased focus on mobilising domestic resources for health initiatives and security.

For example, when the COVID-19 pandemic struck in 2020, Ghana had to rely heavily on the benevolence of the

international donor partners to be able to raise the needed funding to curb or ameliorate the situation at that time; absence of which could have had far reaching public health consequences on the Ghanaian population.

Public health threats do not only endanger lives but also have far-reaching economic ramifications, disrupting livelihoods, deepening the poverty gap, and impeding economic growth.

Mr Speaker, the National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO), the coordinating body for all emergencies in the country, has in place a multi-hazard emergency preparedness and response plan and also a water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH) emergency preparedness and response plan. However, there is a need for a more specific and targeted plan for dealing with public health emergencies and health security threats with accompanying funding arrangements to ensure effective implementation.

Mr Speaker, lessons from the COVID-19 pandemic ultimately highlight the crucial need for sustainable funding to tackle such health emergencies when they arise. It is imperative that we develop a policy that will help address the gaps in Ghana's Health Security in a multisectoral approach with clear coordination mechanisms and dedicated funding to help Ghana address the challenges and meet the World Health Organization's

(WHO) benchmark for domestic financing mechanisms for health emergencies and health security.

Commendably Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Health has already taken the bold step of developing a Health Security Policy, which includes a sustainable funding component to address a broad range of public health threats amongst others effectively. Enacting the Health Security Policy will strengthen Ghana's legislation and financing capacity for the implementation of the International Health Regulations.

Mr Speaker, this health security policy has already garnered support of civil society, the academia and other stakeholders. I therefore urge my Colleagues here to support the Health Security Bill when it arrives in Parliament since it will go a long way to safeguard lives and promote good health as we seek to build a better Ghana. Afterall, as the saying goes, "a healthy nation is a wealthy nation". Your support is therefore essential in ensuring that this Bill is passed so that Ghana gets the resources needed to prepare for and manage health threats as and when they arise.

I am very grateful, Mr Speaker for this opportunity to make this Statement.

7:00 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. I am taking one from each Side.

Let me listen to Hon Isaac Boamah-Nyarko, but the comment should be brief.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, and let me commend Hon Joseph Kwame Kumah, Member of Parliament for Kintampo North, for this timely Statement on the Health Security Fund for Ghana. Mr Speaker, as he said, the Kintampo Health Research Centre is well-known for its research into health services or health-related diseases, and I wonder about the state of the Kintampo Health Service today. If you take the services that it used to render for this country, I think the Ministry of Health needs to take particular notice and attention. With the Deputy Minister for Health sitting right here, the Member of Parliament for Essikadu-Ketan, she should please go to the Kintampo Health Service and let us see how best we can support them in their work.

But, Mr Speaker, importantly, he raised the issue about funding for non-communicable diseases. If we check statistics today, smoking in Ghana has decreased because of the way and manner we tax excise duty on cigarettes in this country. Per the data we have, which is the World Health Organization (WHO) recent briefing to the Finance Committee and Committee on Health, the total consumption of cigarettes, which stood at around 2.6 billion sticks in 2023, has reduced to 1.4 billion, almost 100 per cent down in 2024. This is because of the taxes this House imposed, specifically on *ad valorem* on cigarettes. And so, we have increased

revenue by over 300 per cent and yet reduced the intake of cigarettes. The data tells us that drinking—I am happy the Chairperson of the Committee on Health is around, drinking is now the biggest challenge that we are seeing in this country, with over 30 per cent of our adult population is involved in drinking. So, we need to have a look at how best we are going to also address this issue of drinking.

Mr Speaker, funding for these diseases is very critical. In this House, we established a National Health Insurance Levy (NHIL) to support health facilities and health infrastructure. However, the current Government has taken 20 per cent of the National Health Insurance funding for MahamaCares without giving us any further means of improving revenue generation into the National Health Insurance mechanism. Mr Speaker, it is important that we look at funding to support the health sector. Mr Speaker, on the National Disaster Management Organization (NADMO) issues that he raised, NADMO is also heavily underfunded by this particular Government. If we check the Budget Statement and Economic Policy for 2024, 2025 and 2026, funding for NADMO activities has also gone down. And so, it is important for the Minister for Finance to make sure that we provide adequate funding.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion to this particular Statement that was ably delivered by Hon Kumah, it is a right call that we look at how best we are going to provide funding to support these particular areas and health service

delivery in this country. Because, as he said, a healthy body is a wealthy body that gives us a wealthy nation. I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah (NDC — Garu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this wonderful Statement ably made by my Colleague requesting a possible establishment of a health security policy. I think that is a good call, and I think that if he had monitored H.E. John Dramani Mahama since he came to power, the first good thing he did in health was to land what we call the health sovereignty. He is encouraging all African leaders, his colleagues, to ensure that we actually invest in our health sector instead of depending heavily on donor partners. As a result of that, we could realise that last year's Budget, there was funding made available for the sudden cessation of US aid to Ghana, which enabled Ghana to procure vaccines and other essential drugs that we were dependent on donor contributions. That is to tell you that, yes, the country is already in motion and encouraging other countries. He invited a lot of countries to come for the launch of the health sovereignty in Accra, Ghana, last year, and this is what we are heading towards. We are no longer depending heavily, as he has mentioned, on donor funding to run our health sector.

One thing we would also notice is that we have something called the “sin tax” in Ghana, which is taxes that we impose on commodities we consume, leading to the development of chronic

diseases. This “sin tax” is taken from alcohol, cigarettes, and drugs that are very dangerous. Some of us would propose that when we collect these taxes, we should use the levies that we get from the National Health Insurance to gear towards treating non-communicable diseases and diseases that are generated from these commodities that we consume. Some of these commodities include cigarettes, alcohol, and the latest one is *shisha*. People who use *shisha* develop lung diseases, and I think that Government should be working hard to ensure that we have a tax on *shisha* in Ghana to ensure that the money is kept aside to take care of people who depend on *shisha* for fancy lifestyles.

Another commodity that we are proposing, and some of us think that the Government should be taxing, is these whitening creams or lotions, bleaching. Some of the whitening lotions contain mercury. We are all here fighting against *galamsey*. Meanwhile, our women want to impress us. I know a few men do it, but generally, our women want to impress us. Look, I love the black colour; it is very beautiful. Have your black colour because some of these creams that contain mercury for whitening can cause kidney disease. Some of them contain steroids, and those steroids will affect the liver; those steroids would affect the kidney, those steroids would cause hypertension, and they would cause heart diseases. So, let us also put taxes on these creams or lotions that we import into

Ghana for the women to use to bleach themselves.

One other thing I will say is that even the WHO itself is now encouraging developing countries to try and find funding within to spend prudently, as H.E. John Dramani Mahama has done. He has uncapped the National Health Insurance, and the money is going into the health sector to an extent that we have even gotten more money to an extent that we have used some for the MahamaCares, which is a Ghana Medical Trust Fund. In addition, some of the money is now even going to primary health care, which is supposed to be used to pluck the low-hanging fruit, manage the people, and ensure that they know what to do to prevent themselves from getting those diseases that will give us the burden of having to look for money for health emergencies.

To this end, Mr Speaker, I thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am not admitting any comment again. We have spent more than seven hours, and therefore, I will proceed to adjourn the House.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 7:11 p.m. till Friday, 13th March, 2026, at 12:00 p.m.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was corrected by the House on 19th March, 2026.

Column 106, last paragraph, “Second Deputy Majority Whip” was replaced with “Majority Chief Whip”

Column 114, last paragraph, line 5, “Assembly” was replaced with “Assemblies”.

Column 158, paragraph 3, “NPP” was deleted and “NDC” inserted.

Column 109, paragraph 4, “*Referred to the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs*” was inserted.